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United Nations Security Council

“Research paper-I”

INDIAN SCHOOL DAR-ES-SALAAM MODEL UNITED NATIONS

RESEARCH PAPER

Council: United Nations Security Council (UNSC)

Issue: Examining the Legitimacy, Scope, and Limitations of International Intervention in Sovereign States for the Protection of Civilians

Position: Security Council President / Chair

Student Officer: Afreen

Introduction of the Topic

The protection of civilians during armed conflict and mass atrocity is one of the most difficult responsibilities facing the international community. When a government is unable or unwilling to protect people within its territory, other states and international institutions face a serious dilemma: whether to respect sovereignty and avoid intervention, or to take action to prevent grave human suffering. International intervention may include diplomacy, mediation, humanitarian assistance, sanctions, peacekeeping, arms embargoes, international investigations, and, in exceptional circumstances, the use of force authorized by the United Nations Security Council.

The issue is not simply whether intervention is morally desirable. It is also whether it has a valid legal basis, whether the proposed action is necessary and proportionate, whether it is likely to protect civilians in practice, and whether those carrying it out can be held accountable. The UN Charter protects the sovereign equality and territorial integrity of states and generally prohibits the threat or use of force. At the same time, it gives the Security Council primary responsibility for international peace and security and permits enforcement action under Chapter VII when the Council determines that the required conditions are met.

The 2005 World Summit Outcome affirmed that each state has a responsibility to protect its population from genocide, war crimes, ethnic cleansing, and crimes against humanity. It also recognized a role for the international community, acting through the United Nations and in accordance with the Charter, where peaceful means are inadequate and national authorities are manifestly failing to protect their populations. This commitment, known as the Responsibility to Protect (R2P), is not a blanket authorization for unilateral military action. It must be understood within the existing framework of international law.

For the Security Council, the central challenge is to respond credibly to threats against civilians without allowing humanitarian language to become a pretext for regime change, geopolitical advantage, or unlawful interference. A legitimate response should be evidence-based, impartial, limited to its authorized purpose, and accompanied by monitoring and accountability.

Definition of Key Terms

State sovereignty:

The authority of a state to govern its territory and make domestic decisions independently, subject to its obligations under international law.

International intervention:

Action by external states or international organizations to influence or respond to a situation within another state. It can be diplomatic, humanitarian, economic, legal, or military.

Responsibility to Protect (R2P):

The 2005 commitment that states must protect populations from genocide, war crimes, ethnic cleansing, and crimes against humanity, with international assistance and collective action through the UN where appropriate.

Legitimacy:

The justification and acceptability of an intervention, including its legal basis, purpose, proportionality, fairness, and likely consequences. Legitimacy and legality are related but not identical.

Chapter VII:

The part of the UN Charter under which the Security Council may determine a threat to the peace, breach of the peace, or act of aggression and decide measures, including non-military measures and, where necessary, military action.

Protection of civilians (PoC):

Actions intended to reduce threats to civilians and ensure respect for applicable international humanitarian law, human rights law, and refugee law.

Proportionality:

The requirement that the scale, duration, and effects of a response are not excessive in relation to its legitimate objective; in armed conflict, specific legal tests also apply to attacks.

Humanitarian access:

Safe, timely, and unimpeded access for humanitarian personnel and relief to people in need, consistent with applicable law.

Background of the Issue

The modern legal framework emerged after the Second World War. The UN Charter established sovereign equality as a foundation of the Organization and prohibited states from threatening or using force against another state's territorial integrity or political independence, subject to recognized Charter exceptions. Article 2(7) limits UN intervention in matters essentially within domestic jurisdiction, while expressly preserving the application of Chapter VII enforcement measures. These provisions must be read together rather than treating sovereignty or civilian protection as an absolute rule that overrides all others. [1]

The International Court of Justice has also emphasized the principles of non-use of force and non-intervention. In its 1986 judgment in Nicaragua v. United States, the Court found that the United States had breached customary international law obligations relating to non-intervention and the use of force. The case remains an important reminder that a state's political objectives do not automatically make coercive interference lawful. [3]

In 2005, UN Member States endorsed the Responsibility to Protect in paragraphs 138 and 139 of the World Summit Outcome. The commitment focuses on four atrocity crimes: genocide, war crimes, ethnic cleansing, and crimes against humanity. It places the primary responsibility on each state, encourages international assistance, and envisages collective action through the Security Council, in accordance with the Charter, when peaceful means are inadequate and national authorities are manifestly failing to protect populations. [2]

The Security Council has developed a wider protection-of-civilians agenda. Resolution 1894 (2009), for example, demanded compliance with international humanitarian, human rights, and refugee law; condemned attacks directed against civilians; and stressed the importance of clear, credible, and achievable mandates for peacekeeping missions tasked with civilian protection. These expectations show that authorizing a mission is only one part of the task: the Council must also consider resources, implementation, reporting, and oversight. [4]

International intervention can take many forms. Diplomatic engagement and mediation may reduce tensions without coercion. Humanitarian assistance can help people survive but does not itself resolve the political causes of a conflict. Targeted sanctions and arms embargoes may increase pressure on perpetrators, although poorly designed measures can harm ordinary people or be evaded. Peacekeeping may protect civilians when missions have an appropriate mandate, resources, consent or cooperation where relevant, and realistic rules for operating. Military force is the most coercive option and therefore requires the strongest legal and practical scrutiny.

Previous Attempts to Address the Issue

The Responsibility to Protect framework

The 2005 World Summit Outcome created a shared political commitment to prevent and respond to the four atrocity crimes. UN explanations commonly organize R2P around three pillars: the state's responsibility to protect its population; international assistance and capacity-building; and timely and decisive collective response when a state is manifestly failing to protect its population. R2P therefore includes prevention and assistance, not only military action. [2, 5]

Security Council action on civilian protection

Resolution 1894 (2009) reaffirmed the Council's concern for civilians in armed conflict and emphasized that parties must comply with international humanitarian law and facilitate humanitarian assistance. It also stressed that peacekeeping mandates should be clear, credible, and achievable, with adequate resources and training. The resolution demonstrates the value of linking political decisions to practical implementation and reporting. [4]

International judicial accountability

The International Court of Justice clarifies disputes between states and their obligations under international law, while international criminal mechanisms may address individual responsibility for international crimes within their jurisdiction. These mechanisms can support accountability, but they do not replace urgent protection measures or automatically resolve political deadlock in the Security Council. The Nicaragua judgment illustrates the importance of legal scrutiny of coercive intervention. [3]

Diplomatic, humanitarian, and regional approaches

Mediation, humanitarian diplomacy, regional organizations, early-warning systems, and capacity-building can help prevent escalation and may be more acceptable to affected states. Under the UN Charter, regional arrangements can play a role in maintaining peace and security, but enforcement action by regional arrangements generally requires Security Council authorization under Article 53. Coordination is therefore important to avoid competing mandates and fragmented responses. [1]

Despite these efforts, implementation remains uneven. Political divisions among permanent members can delay or block Council action. States may disagree over the evidence of atrocities, the appropriate response, or whether a proposed operation serves civilian protection or strategic interests. Even when action is authorized, weak planning, inadequate resources, civilian casualties, unclear objectives, and the absence of a post-conflict strategy can undermine the intended protection.

Possible Solutions and Recommendations

As Chair, the objective is not to advocate for or against intervention in every case, but to guide delegates toward a lawful, evidence-based, proportionate, and civilian-centred framework. The Security Council may consider the following approaches:

Apply a clear legal threshold

Any proposed coercive action should identify its legal basis and explain how it complies with the UN Charter. Delegates should distinguish R2P's four atrocity crimes from broader claims of humanitarian concern and should not treat R2P as an independent authorization for unilateral force. Where force is proposed, the Council should examine whether there is a valid Charter basis, including a relevant Security Council authorization or another recognized legal basis.

Prioritize prevention and peaceful measures

The Council should strengthen early warning, fact-finding, mediation, diplomatic pressure, humanitarian access, and support for national institutions. Where feasible, peaceful measures should be attempted and assessed before escalation. However, prevention must not become an excuse for endless delay when credible evidence indicates an imminent or ongoing atrocity risk.

Use necessity, proportionality, and a defined objective

Any measure should be tied to a specific civilian-protection objective, such as preventing attacks on civilians or enabling humanitarian relief. The Council should consider likely benefits, foreseeable harm, available alternatives, geographic scope, duration, and conditions for review or termination. A mandate should not be interpreted as permission to pursue unrelated political or military goals.

Establish monitoring and accountability

Resolutions authorizing action should require regular reporting to the Council, credible monitoring of civilian harm, transparent investigation of alleged violations, and review of whether the operation remains necessary and within its mandate. Troop-contributing states and other actors should have clear reporting responsibilities. Allegations of misconduct must be investigated through appropriate mechanisms.

Protect humanitarian neutrality and access

Humanitarian agencies must be able to deliver assistance according to need and the principles of humanity, neutrality, impartiality, and independence. Parties should facilitate safe access, and military operations should avoid treating humanitarian organizations as extensions of a political or military strategy. The Council should consider the effects of sanctions and other measures on food, medicine, essential services, and vulnerable groups.

Include regional actors and affected communities

Regional organizations and neighbouring states may offer local knowledge, mediation capacity, and logistical support. Their involvement should be consistent with the Charter and should not undermine the rights of affected populations. Consultation with local civil society, humanitarian organizations, women, displaced people, and community representatives can help identify risks that may be missed by external decision-makers.

Plan for the aftermath

A credible intervention strategy must consider what happens after immediate violence is reduced. Plans should address security-sector reform, inclusive political dialogue, justice and reconciliation, the return or resettlement of displaced

people, reconstruction, and the transfer of responsibilities to legitimate local institutions. Without a realistic post-intervention plan, short-term protection may be followed by instability or renewed violence.

Reduce selectivity and double standards

The Council should assess situations against consistent criteria rather than the strategic importance of the state concerned. While each case requires its own evidence and response, transparent explanations for action or inaction can improve confidence in the Council. Permanent members should explain how their positions relate to civilian risk, the Charter, and the likely consequences of proposed measures.

Other Relevant Information

A key distinction for debate is the difference between legality and legitimacy. An intervention may be described as morally urgent yet lack a clear legal basis; conversely, a measure may be formally authorized but still be poorly designed, disproportionate in practice, or ineffective at protecting civilians. The Council should therefore assess both legal authority and likely real-world consequences.

Another important distinction is between intervention and protection. Intervention is a means; civilian protection is the objective. More force does not automatically mean more protection. Military action can deter attacks in some circumstances, but it can also cause civilian casualties, displacement, retaliation, infrastructure damage, or a power vacuum. Non-military measures can also have harmful consequences if poorly targeted or inadequately monitored.

The Security Council's credibility depends on its ability to balance urgent action with restraint. The Council should ask: What evidence supports the threat assessment? Which civilians face danger, and from whom? What is the legal basis? What peaceful alternatives are available? What is the narrowest effective mandate? How will civilian harm be measured and reported? Who is accountable if the mandate is exceeded? What happens when the mission ends?

For chairing purposes, delegates should be encouraged to evaluate proposals rather than rely on slogans such as 'sovereignty always comes first' or 'humanitarian need justifies any action.' Sovereignty is a central principle of international order, and states retain their legal protections; it does not remove a state's responsibility to protect its population. Equally, the protection of civilians does not grant outside states unrestricted authority to use force. The Security Council's task is to assess each case under the Charter and applicable international law, with the protection of civilians as a central practical test.

Questions for Delegates to Consider

· What evidence and threshold should the Council require before deciding that international action is necessary?

· How can the Council distinguish a genuine civilian-protection operation from an intervention motivated by regime change or strategic advantage?

· When should the Council prioritize diplomacy, sanctions, peacekeeping, or humanitarian access over military force?

· What monitoring and accountability mechanisms should accompany any protection mandate?

· How can the Council respond when permanent-member disagreements delay action despite credible reports of atrocity crimes?

· What obligations should intervening actors have toward civilians after the immediate threat has been reduced?

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“Research paper-II”

Forum: Security Council

Issue: Safeguarding Freedom of Navigation in Strategic Maritime Chokepoints: Balancing National Security, International Law, and the Prevention of Regional Escalation

Student Officer: Amaan Riyaz Sherif

Position: Deputy Chair

Introduction

Over 80% of global merchandise trade by volume and more than 70% by value is transported by sea. The structural stability of this global supply network depends heavily on transit through a small number of narrow maritime passages known as strategic chokepoints. Waterways such as the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, the Strait of Hormuz, the Strait of Malacca, the Suez and Panama Canals, and the Turkish Straits serve as indispensable conduits for energy, raw materials, agricultural products, and manufactured goods. In recent years, these maritime corridors have increasingly become focal points of geopolitical confrontation, asymmetric warfare, and hybrid security threats. State actors utilize maritime interdictions, military exercises, excessive territorial claims, and grey-zone operations to project power and leverage economic pressure. Concurrently, non-state armed groups equipped with advanced asymmetric warfare capabilities—including anti-ship ballistic missiles (ASBMs), land-attack cruise missiles (LACMs), uncrewed aerial vehicles (UAVs), and uncrewed surface vessels (USVs)—have demonstrated the capacity to disrupt commercial shipping lanes. The degradation of security in strategic chokepoints imposes systemic strain on the global economy. Mass rerouting of commercial traffic around Africa's Cape of Good Hope increases transit times by 10 to 14 days, elevates fuel consumption, spikes insurance premiums, and accelerates global inflationary pressures. Furthermore, international military responses—such as coalition naval deployments and targeted strikes—must continuously navigate a fine boundary under international law to protect commercial shipping without triggering wider regional military escalation. The United Nations Security Council is tasked with reinforcing the international legal framework governing maritime transit—primarily anchored in the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS)—while addressing the root political causes of maritime insecurity and establishing sustainable mechanisms to protect global sea lines of communication (SLOCs).

Definition of Key Terms

Freedom of Navigation (FON)

A foundational principle of customary international law and UNCLOS which dictates that ships flying the flag of any sovereign state shall enjoy unhindered transit on the high seas and within Exclusive Economic Zones (EEZs), subject only to specific exceptions provided under international law.

Strategic Maritime Chokepoint

A narrow, naturally occurring geographic channel connecting major ocean basins or seas that concentrates high volumes of maritime commercial traffic. Because of their geographic constraints and limited alternative routes, chokepoints are exceptionally vulnerable to military blockades, piracy, terrorism, asymmetric strikes, and maritime accidents.

Transit Passage

A regime under Part III of UNCLOS (Articles 37–44) applying to straits used for international navigation between one part of the high seas or an EEZ and another. It guarantees all ships and aircraft the right of continuous and expeditious transit, which states bordering the strait cannot hamper, suspend, or infringe upon during peacetime.

Innocent Passage

A legal regime under Part II, Section 3 of UNCLOS allowing foreign ships to traverse a coastal state’s territorial sea (up to 12 nautical miles from baselines) as long as the passage is not prejudicial to the peace, good order, or security of the coastal state. Unlike transit passage, innocent passage does not include overflight rights, and submarines are required to navigate on the surface and show their flag.

Sea Lines of Communication (SLOCs)

The primary maritime trade routes used for military logistics, commercial shipping, and energy transportation between ports. The physical and legal security of SLOCs is essential for national defense, energy security, and international commerce.

Asymmetric Maritime Threats

Methods of naval warfare employed by non-state actors or militarily inferior states to bypass conventional naval power, utilizing relatively low-cost weapons such as loitering munitions, anti-ship ballistic missiles, sea mines, and uncrewed

surface vessels (USVs) to target commercial and military vessels.

Grey-Zone Operations

Coercive political, military, economic, and informational activities conducted by states that fall below the threshold of formal direct military conflict, such as using civilian maritime militias, coast guard harassment, or unannounced live-fire exercises to assert territorial claims.

Background Information

Mechanics of Maritime Chokepoints and Vulnerabilities

Global shipping routes depend on geographic narrowings that create structural vulnerabilities. Disruption at a single chokepoint produces immediate, compounding effects across global supply chains, affecting maritime trade volumes, container availability, energy spot prices, and war-risk insurance premiums.

The Bab el-Mandeb Strait and the Red Sea Crisis

Connecting the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden and the Indian Ocean, the Bab el-Mandeb Strait is an 18-mile-wide channel through which roughly 12% of total global trade and 10% of seaborne petroleum transit annually. Beginning in late 2023, the Houthi movement (Ansar Allah) in Yemen initiated a systematic campaign of maritime attacks against commercial and naval vessels operating in the southern Red Sea and Bab el-Mandeb Strait. Deploying anti-ship ballistic missiles, cruise missiles, loitering UAVs, and explosive USVs, the Houthis targeted scores of commercial vessels, sinking multiple merchant ships, damaging others, and capturing the vehicle carrier Galaxy Leader. These actions forced major container carriers (including Maersk, MSC, Hapag-Lloyd, and CMA CGM) to suspend Red Sea transits, rerouting vessels around the Cape of Good Hope. This shift added roughly 3,500 nautical miles to Asia-Europe voyages, raised fuel expenditure per vessel by over $1 million, reduced effective global shipping capacity by 10–15%, and severely degraded revenue for the Suez Canal and regional economies. In response to these disruptions, international military efforts were launched, including the US-led Operation Prosperity Guardian (December 2023) and the European Union’s defensive naval mission Operation Aspides (February 2024). While these task forces successfully intercepted hundreds of incoming missiles and drones, coalition kinetic strikes against ground targets in Yemen raised a contentious legal debate regarding the scope of self-defense under Article 51 of the UN Charter versus military escalation.

The Strait of Hormuz and Persian Gulf Energy Security

The Strait of Hormuz, bounded by Iran to the north and Oman/UAE to the south, is the world's most critical oil transit chokepoint. An average of 20 to 21 million barrels of petroleum per day—representing roughly 20% of global petroleum liquids consumption and one-third of total seaborne crude oil—transits the strait daily. Geopolitical friction surrounding Iran, Western sanctions, and regional rivalries frequently manifests in Hormuz. Tactical measures deployed in this chokepoint include:

- Interdiction and forced seizure of foreign-flagged commercial tankers.
- GPS spoofing and electronic warfare targeting vessel navigation systems.
- Conducting high-speed swarming maneuvers using Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps Navy (IRGCN) fast-attack craft.
- Threatening complete closure of the strait during heightened geopolitical disputes.

Because global oil markets have minimal spare production capacity outside the Persian Gulf, any sustained interruption of transit through the Strait of Hormuz could trigger immediate global energy shocks.

The Strait of Malacca and the South China Sea Complex

The Strait of Malacca, running between Indonesia, Malaysia, and Singapore, connects the Indian Ocean to the Pacific Ocean and serves as the primary sea route for East Asian economies. Over 80,000 vessels transit the strait annually, carrying an estimated 25% of all traded goods and roughly 60% of China’s petroleum imports. This creates the strategic vulnerability known as the "Malacca Dilemma"—a major power's vulnerability to naval blockades or interdictions at the strait during international crises. Directly northeast of Malacca lies the South China Sea, a critical maritime domain through which over $3.3 trillion in annual trade passes. China claims historic sovereignty over nearly the entire sea via its expansive "nine-dash line" (and updated ten-dash line), conflicting with the Exclusive Economic Zones and territorial claims of the Philippines, Vietnam, Malaysia, Brunei, and Taiwan. Key flashpoints in this region include:

- Militarization of Features: Construction and militarization of artificial islands equipped with airfields, radar arrays, and anti-ship missile systems in the Spratly and Paracel Islands.
- Grey-Zone Coercion: Deployment of maritime militia fleets and Coast Guard vessels to disrupt lawful resource exploration, fishing, and resupply missions within neighbor states' EEZs.
- Freedom of Navigation Operations (FONOPs): The regular transit of US and allied warships through contested waters to challenge claims deemed excessive under UNCLOS, resulting in periodic close-quarters military interactions.

The Turkish Straits and Black Sea Dynamics

The Bosporus and Dardanelles Straits connect the Black Sea to the Mediterranean, operating under the distinct legal framework of the 1936 Montreux Convention. Following the outbreak of conflict in Ukraine, Turkey invoked Article 19 of

the Montreux Convention to close the straits to warships of belligerent nations. While this move contained naval military expansion in the Black Sea, commercial shipping continued to face risks from sea mines, port bombardments, and political threats to agricultural trade corridors.

Major Countries and Organizations Involved

United States of America

The United States maintains a significant naval presence globally to enforce freedom of navigation and safeguard maritime trade. Through the US Navy's Fifth Fleet (headquartered in Bahrain) and Seventh Fleet (headquartered in Japan), the US leads international naval initiatives, including Operation Prosperity Guardian and Combined Maritime Forces (CMF). Though the US has not formally ratified UNCLOS, it recognizes its navigational provisions as reflective of customary international law and routinely conducts FONOPs worldwide.

People's Republic of China

China is the world's largest trading nation by volume and relies on unhindered transit through maritime chokepoints, particularly Malacca, Bab el-Mandeb, and Hormuz, for its energy and raw material imports. Simultaneously, China asserts expansive territorial and maritime claims over the South China Sea, rejecting the 2016 Permanent Court of Arbitration ruling that invalidated its historic rights claims. China advocates for managing regional maritime disputes through direct bilateral negotiations, opposing what it views as external military interference by non-regional powers.

Islamic Republic of Iran

Iran borders the northern coastline of the Strait of Hormuz and exercises significant influence over the strategic access routes to the Persian Gulf. Iran views Western naval presences in regional waters as a threat to its national security and maintains naval forces capable of asymmetric interdiction. Iran also provides political, financial, and military backing to regional allies, including the Houthi movement in Yemen.

Yemen (Ansar Allah / Houthi Movement)

Controlling significant territory in western Yemen along the Red Sea coast, Ansar Allah has transformed the Bab el-Mandeb Strait into an active asymmetric combat zone. The Houthis have utilized anti-ship ballistic missiles, drones, and USVs to strike commercial shipping, framing their actions as a regional response to broader geopolitical conflicts.

European Union Member States

EU nations rely heavily on Red Sea shipping routes for trade with Asia. In February 2024, the EU launched Operation Aspides—a dedicated defensive maritime security operation designed to escort commercial vessels, intercept air and sea attacks, and safeguard navigation in the Red Sea, Gulf of Aden, and Persian Gulf, maintaining a strictly defensive mandate.

International Maritime Organization (IMO)

The IMO is the United Nations specialized agency responsible for the safety and security of shipping and the prevention of marine pollution by ships. The IMO establishes maritime safety zones, standardizes automatic identification system (AIS) regulations, issues security alerts, and coordinates technical support for coastal states to counter piracy and armed robbery at sea.

United Nations Security Council (UNSC)

The Security Council holds primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security under the UN Charter. The Council has adopted pivotal resolutions addressing chokepoint security, condemning maritime attacks, enforcing arms embargoes, and extending monitoring mandates.

Timeline of Events

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Date (Start - End)	Event / Name	Description
July 20, 1936	Adoption of the Montreux Convention	Signed in Switzerland, granting Turkey control over the Bosporus and Dardanelles Straits and regulating the transit of naval warships during peacetime and war.
December 10, 1982	Adoption of UNCLOS III	The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea was opened for signature in Montego Bay, Jamaica, establishing codified regimes for Transit Passage and EEZs.
March 10, 1988	Adoption of the SUA Convention	The Convention for the Suppression of Unlawful Acts against the Safety of Maritime Navigation was adopted to suppress illegal acts against commercial ships.
July 12, 2016	South China Sea Arbitration Ruling	The Permanent Court of Arbitration in The Hague ruled unanimously against China's historic "nine-dash line" claims in favor of the Philippines under UNCLOS.
May 2019 – July 2021	Persian Gulf Tanker Incidents	A series of limpet mine attacks, seizures, and boardings targeting foreign oil tankers occurred near the Strait of Hormuz amid heightened regional tensions.
March 23–29, 2021	Ever Given Suez Canal Blockage	A 400-meter container ship ran aground in the Suez Canal, completely halting global trade through the Red Sea route for six days and disrupting over $9 billion in daily commercial shipping.
November 19, 2023	Seizure of the Galaxy Leader	Houthi militants hijacked the merchant vessel Galaxy Leader in the Red Sea, marking a major escalation in asymmetric attacks against commercial shipping.
December 18, 2023	Establishment of Operation Prosperity Guardian	The US and international partners launched a multinational maritime security coalition to protect Red Sea shipping from air and sea attacks.
January 10, 2024	Adoption of UNSC Resolution 2722	The Security Council explicitly condemned Houthi attacks on merchant vessels, demanded an immediate end to hostilities, and affirmed member states' right to defend vessels.
February 19, 2024	Launch of EU Operation Aspides	The European Union deployed a defensive

		naval mission in the Red Sea and Persian Gulf to escort merchant shipping and intercept incoming attacks.
June 27, 2024	Adoption of UNSC Resolution 2739	The Security Council extended the Secretary-General's monthly reporting mandate on Red Sea maritime attacks.
January 14, 2026	Adoption of UNSC Resolution 2812	The Security Council renewed the Secretary-General's reporting requirement on Red Sea shipping security through mid-2026.
July 14, 2026	Adoption of UNSC Resolution 2826	The Security Council extended the Secretary-General's reporting mandate on Red Sea maritime attacks for another six months through January 15, 2027.

Economic and Financial Committee (ECOFIN I)

“Research paper-I”

Council: EcoFin 1 (Economic and Financial Committee)

Issue: Evaluating the Need for Comprehensive Reform of International Sovereign Debt Mechanisms to Address Debt Vulnerability in Developing Economies

Position: President Chair

Student Officer: Ansh Sareen

Introduction of the Topic:

Borrowing is a normal and often useful part of running a country. A government that borrows to build roads, schools, ports and power plants can raise long-term growth and repay the loan from a larger economy. The trouble begins when the cost of debt grows faster than the economy and the state has to choose between paying its creditors and paying for its people. For a growing number of developing economies, that choice is no longer hypothetical. According to the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD), global public debt reached a record 102 trillion US dollars in 2024. Developing countries owe roughly 31 trillion of it, and their public debt has grown about twice as fast as that of advanced economies since 2010. Their external debt stood at 11.7 trillion dollars in 2024, and UNCTAD estimates that they paid a record 921 billion dollars in net interest on public debt in the same year. A record 61 developing economies now spend at least 10 percent of government revenue on interest alone, and 45 spend more on interest than on health. Not only is the size of the debt a concern, but so is the structure through which the debt is controlled. In the case where the country cannot pay back its debts, there is no formal method that is internationally accepted to determine the losses that will be incurred and at what rate. This is usually done on a case-by-case basis. One major question is posed to the Committee: Is there any possibility of improving the current structure on a step-by-step basis, or is a complete overhaul of the debt architecture required?

Definition of Key Terms:

Sovereign Debt: Money borrowed by a national government, through loans from other governments and institutions or through bonds sold to investors, that the state is legally bound to repay. Debt Vulnerability: A situation in which a country faces a high risk of being unable to meet its debt obligations without severe cuts to essential spending or a sudden financial shock. Debt Sustainability Analysis (DSA): The assessment, carried out mainly by the IMF and World Bank, of whether a country can service its debt over time without needing exceptional relief. Debt Restructuring: A negotiated change to the terms of existing debt, such as longer repayment periods, lower interest or a reduction in the amount owed. G20 Common Framework: A mechanism launched in November 2020 to coordinate debt treatments for eligible low-income countries between the Paris Club and other official bilateral creditors, including China. Collective Action Clauses (CACs): Provisions in bond contracts allowing a qualified majority of bondholders to accept a restructuring that then binds the minority, limiting holdout creditors. Net Negative Transfer: The situation in which a country pays more in debt service to external creditors than it receives in new financing.

Background of the Issue:

Debt crises are not new. The Latin American debt crisis of the 1980s led to the Brady Plan of 1989, and the Jubilee 2000 movement helped drive the Heavily Indebted Poor Countries (HIPC) Initiative of 1996 and the Multilateral Debt Relief Initiative of 2005, which wrote off large amounts of debt owed by the poorest countries. These efforts mainly dealt with debt owed to governments and international institutions. Since then the creditor landscape has changed completely. Low interest rates after 2008 drew many developing countries into international bond markets, and new official lenders, above all China, became major creditors. By 2023, private creditors held about 60 percent of developing countries’ external

public debt, according to UNCTAD. A single restructuring may now involve the Paris Club, China, bondholders and commercial banks, all with different rules and different incentives. Shocks then arrived in quick succession: the COVID-19 pandemic, the energy and food price crisis, and the sharp rise in global interest rates from 2022. Zambia defaulted in 2020, Sri Lanka and Ghana in 2022, and Ethiopia in 2023. UNCTAD reports that between 2014 and 2024 the cost of servicing external debt rose by 111 percent while the stock of external debt rose by only 42 percent. Developing countries also paid about 25 billion dollars more to external creditors than they received in new financing in 2023. Africa holds 38 percent of developing countries and 22 percent of their population, but received only 10 percent of external financial inflows between 2014 and 2024. The burden does not fall equally on all nations. In relative figures, although most of the debt of the developing world is held by large countries in Asia, the biggest burden is borne by the poorest countries. As per the statistics by UNCTAD for 2024, the poorest countries utilized 24.2 percent of their exports to cover external debt costs and 18.1 percent of their budget to pay for the cost of servicing their external debt, while developing countries without China recorded an increase from 7 percent to 8.4 percent of their revenues allocated towards the same purpose. Interest payments constitute another less apparent component of the issue. UNCTAD suggests that developing countries encounter higher interest rates compared to advanced nations because the ratings and risk perceptions of the markets are generally overly negative in relation to fundamentals. UNCTAD claims that the extra cost that developing nations pay for their debt annually constitutes a massive amount. Furthermore, concessional financing is declining. UNCTAD notes that the share of aid in the form of debt relief is at its lowest ever level. Consequently, a country that already has problems with its financial status borrows at higher costs, receives fewer funds, and has less space for investments in growth. The consequence is that debt service competes directly with development. UNICEF and UNCTAD have noted that 45 developing countries spend more on interest than on health, and 22 spend more than on education, which makes debt a question of human development as much as of finance.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue:

The HIPC Initiative and the Multilateral Debt Relief Initiative remain the most generous relief programmes to date, but they were designed for a world in which most poor-country debt was owed to official lenders. In 2001 to 2003 the IMF proposed a Sovereign Debt Restructuring Mechanism, a kind of international bankruptcy procedure, but it was not adopted. The international community instead relied on market-based tools, chiefly collective action clauses, which were strengthened after litigation by holdout creditors against Argentina. During the pandemic the G20 launched the Debt Service Suspension Initiative (2020 to 2021), which postponed roughly 13 billion dollars in payments for dozens of countries. It was temporary and voluntary, private creditors did not take part, and it only delayed the problem. The G20 Common Framework followed in November 2020, but only four countries have applied to it: Chad, Zambia, Ghana and Ethiopia. Zambia’s restructuring kept its economy in limbo for more than three and a half years, and Ethiopia, which asked for treatment in early 2021, only announced an agreement with China in April 2026. Critics, including the UN Secretary-General and the IMF Managing Director, have called the process slow, and middle-income countries such as Sri Lanka are not eligible. Smaller, targeted tools have also been tried. Debt-for-nature swaps, such as those arranged by Belize and Ecuador, exchange expensive debt for cheaper financing tied to conservation spending, and Barbados has championed clauses that pause payments after natural disasters. These show that creative contracts are possible, but they remain limited in scale and have so far been used by only a handful of countries, which is why many observers argue that they complement, but cannot replace, a stronger overall system. Some other efforts made in more recent times include the Global Sovereign Debt Roundtable, whose aim is to enhance the timeliness and availability of information exchange among debtors and creditors, and the Sevilla Commitment, which was adopted at the Fourth International Conference on Financing for Development in 2025 and subsequently supported by UN General Assembly Resolution 79/323. The Sevilla Commitment uses the G20 Common Framework as the cornerstone and calls for broader participation, but does not create a binding arrangement. In April 2026 UNCTAD launched a Borrowers’ Platform that enables developing nations’ finance ministers to collaborate and exchange their experience, as part of a preparatory program before the IMF–World Bank Annual Meetings in October 2026. UNCTAD also maintains a Debt Management Program in approximately 60 countries.

Possible Solutions:

The Committee may wish to consider the following options, keeping in mind that they are not mutually exclusive and that each has costs and trade-offs. -Binding Multilateral Framework: Delegates may debate establishing a permanent, rules-based sovereign debt workout mechanism, for example through a UN framework convention on sovereign debt. Supporters argue that it would replace case-by-case bargaining with predictable rules. Opponents warn that major creditors may refuse to join and that a new body could take years to negotiate. -Reforming the Common Framework: Less ambitious but faster, reforms could set firm timelines, trigger a standstill on payments once a country enters the process, ensure comparable treatment from all creditors, and extend eligibility to vulnerable middle-income countries. -Reforming Debt Sustainability Analysis: Assessments could give more weight to development, health and climate needs, and be more transparent about assumptions, so that countries are not pushed to restructure too late or to cut essential spending to repay. -Crisis-Resilient Debt Instruments: Climate-resilient debt clauses, GDP-linked bonds and automatic pause clauses would let payments be suspended after disasters or severe shocks, reducing the need for emergency

negotiations. -Lowering the Cost of Borrowing: Expanding the lending capacity of multilateral development banks, offering guarantees, rechanneling Special Drawing Rights and developing local-currency bond markets could reduce the high interest premiums that developing countries pay. -Debt Swaps and Targeted Relief: Debt-for-development, debt-for-climate and debt-for-nature swaps could convert part of a country's debt into investment in health, education or climate adaptation. Their strength is that they link relief to visible results, while their weakness is that deals are complex, slow to arrange and rarely large enough to change a country's overall debt position. -Strengthening the Voice of Borrowers: Stronger representation for developing countries in the governance of the IMF and World Bank, and a permanent role for borrower-led groups, could ensure that the people who live with the consequences of debt rules also help to write them. -Transparency and Responsible Lending: Public debt registries, disclosure of loan contracts, stronger debt management capacity through bodies such as the Borrowers' Platform, and shared responsibility between lenders and borrowers can help prevent crises. -Private Creditor Participation: Governments in the jurisdictions whose law governs most sovereign bonds, mainly New York and England, could be encouraged to adopt measures ensuring that private creditors also take part in restructurings.

Other Relevant Information:

Both perspectives must be taken into account. The advocates of wholesale reforms base their arguments on the duration of previous restructurings, the increasing number of creditors and the human toll exacted by high interest payments. The limited reformers base their arguments on the effectiveness of the existing instruments used in the right way, the agreement already reached between Zambia and Ghana with the creditors, and the potential rise in future borrowing costs due to a binding mechanism. Four cases from recent years illustrate how the current framework is working in practice. In December 2020, Zambia became the first default by an African country since the beginning of the pandemic and joined the Common Framework, however, its economy remained in a state of prolonged stagnation as creditors were arguing about how to evaluate the differential treatment of official and private creditors. Finally, it managed to reach an agreement with the official creditors and with bondholders of about 3 billion dollars in Eurobonds. Ghana made its default in 2022, agreed on the basic principles of a debt treatment with the official creditors in January 2024, and formalized the deal through a Memorandum of Understanding in June 2024. Sri Lanka made its default in 2022 and could not use the Common Framework at all, therefore, it had to negotiate outside it, with China's financial assurance facilitating the negotiation process. Ethiopia made its default in 2023 and having requested the treatment in 2021, it concluded the agreement with China only in 2026. These cases are read differently by different delegations. Reformers say that they prove that the process is too slow and uneven, because each country had to wait years while its growth, currency and public services suffered. Others note that all four have now reached or are close to agreements, and that the lessons learned from Zambia reportedly speeded up later cases, which suggests that the existing system is improving and needs refinement instead of replacement. Delegates should also be aware that the key actors have different interests. Debtor countries seek faster relief and a greater voice, while the G20, the Paris Club, China, the IMF, the World Bank and private bondholders each have their own priorities. Any resolution that ignores one of them is unlikely to be implemented. Delegates are encouraged to ask: Who should bear the cost of restructuring? How can relief be made faster without discouraging future lending? And should the architecture be built within existing institutions or through a new, universal body? The topic is also closely linked to the Sustainable Development Goals. Heavy debt service limits what governments can spend on health, education, social protection and climate adaptation, and the gap in financing for development grows wider each year that countries must send more money abroad than they receive. For this reason many developing countries describe sovereign debt reform as a precondition for development, while creditor countries often stress that new financing, trade and domestic revenue reforms are equally important. Delegates should be ready to explain how their proposals would affect both stability for creditors and development outcomes for debtors. Finally, delegates should remember that the Committee is not expected to solve every part of the debt problem in one resolution. The strongest proposals are usually specific about who will act, which institution will carry out the action, how it will be funded and how progress will be measured. Resolutions that name concrete mechanisms, timelines and responsible bodies are far more convincing than general calls for cooperation.

The following guiding questions will help the delegates organize their work on the topic under consideration:

-Is the current system failing due to the poor design of the system or rather due to the way it is implemented? -Would reform target the poorest countries alone, or would it include also middle income countries with high levels of debt? -How could private and non-Paris Club official creditors be brought into the same process as traditional creditors? -How could the IMF and World Bank be involved since they are both creditors and designers of the debt sustainability assessments being used for restructuring purposes? -How could the reform be designed in a way that preserves budget spending for health, education and climate resilience while maintaining creditors' rights? In essence, the question revolves around risk management and equity. The mission of the Committee is to find a solution that restores stability, ensures public expenditure in developing countries and provides investment.

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“Research paper-II”

From: Economic and Financial Committee (ECOFIN)

Issue: Addressing the Global Housing Affordability Crisis: Expanding Access to Affordable Housing While Managing Household Debt and Financial Stability Risk.

Position: Deputy Chair

Student Officer: Saweera Muhammad Tahir

Introduction

As the world transitions, the rapid population growth, global inflation, rising interest rates and monetary policies, are all factors that are contributing into making housing less affordable then ever. People are now paying a huge chunk of their income just for housing alone, which is forcing them to remain with very little to afford for other basic needs such as food, healthcare and education. Around 42% or 3 billion people of the world population lacks the basic need of shelter, due to the affordability crises of housing. Meanwhile, those paying such prices for housing are now failing to provide for other basic needs, leading to consider loans. Therefore, causing household debt, whereby all the members of a single household are limited to spend on other basic necessities. The rapid population growth equals to more people which eventually leads to higher demand for housing. As the number of buyers increases, it intrigues sellers to set much higher prices due to scarcity. Thus, it leads to global inflation as housing crises eventually contributes to the general increase of prices in goods and services overtime. Now that there is global inflation, central banks set monetary policies which raise interest rates to cool down the overheating of the economy which stops the prices from rising too fast. This makes loans more expensive, leading to the inability of the vast majority to afford housing as a whole. The imbalance in the strategy is causing a huge amount of people left homeless.

Definition of Key Terms

● Affordability Crises: A situation whereby the prices of basic need raises much faster then

people's income. Leading to goods and services to be unaffordable for majority of the world population.

● Financial Stability Risk: Expected break down of the financial system which is caused by

a sudden increase in the of people who are unable to make repayments. Thus, threatens banks stability.

● Rapid Population Growth: Refers to the sudden increase in the overall number of people

alive in the world.

● Global Inflation: Is the general increase of pricing in good and services across the world

overtime. Which means, more money buys less then before.

● Rising Interest Rates: The increase in the cost of borrowing money from banks.

● Monetary Policies: Are actions taken by central banks to manage money supply and

interest rates.

Background of the issue

Structural Shifts in Credit Access and Housing Demand

Historically, houses were primarily built to provide shelter. Over recent decades, three forces

combined:

More people (population growth). More people moving to cities (urbanization). Easier rules for financial markets (financial deregulation). The Result: Investors, corporations, and funds began buying property not to live in, but to make a profit (through rent or resale value), turning housing into a commodity like stocks or gold. As millions moved into major cities looking for work, the demand for housing increased rapidly.

However, cities couldn't just quickly build millions of new homes because of:

-Geographical constraints: Lack of physical land (e.g., oceans, mountains surrounding a city). -Spatial constraints: Limited room within already crowded city layouts. -Administrative constraints: Strict zoning laws, slow government permits, and heavy building regulations. Demand was high, supply was stuck low, pushing prices up. To help economies bounce back after major downturns (like the 2008 financial crisis), central banks lowered interest rates. Low interest rates made borrowing money from banks very cheap. Because mortgage loans became easy and cheap to get, millions of buyers and

investors borrowed large sums to buy real estate, driving competition and prices up even further. House prices inflated far faster than regular worker paychecks grew.

The Dynamics of Household Debt Vulnerability

When property values increase significantly faster than incomes, households assume larger debt obligations relative to their income. Higher debt-to-income (DTI) ratios—often exceeding 100% to 150% of annual disposable income in major urban economies—make families sensitive to macroeconomic fluctuations. When unexpected events hit—such as global inflation spikes, employment disruptions, or interest rate increases—household debt-servicing costs absorb upwards of 50% to 60% of monthly income. Household budgets break under this strain,

dampening consumer demand across all economic sectors as families divert income away from food, health services, and education toward non-discretionary mortgage or rent payments.

The Systemic Risk Link to Financial Institutions

Because real estate loans account for 30% to 50% of total bank balance sheets in many jurisdictions, high household debt levels present direct financial stability risks. When widespread defaults occur due to elevated interest rates, non-performing loans (NPLs) erode bank capital reserves. This triggers credit crunches, where financial institutions restrict further lending, exacerbating recessions and deepening the housing availability crisis.

Previous attempt to solve the issue

Governments and international bodies have tested various policy interventions over past

decades, many of which produced unintended side effects:

Deregulation of Credit and Subprime Lending

In an effort to expand homeownership, regulatory authorities lowered credit standards and permitted low-down-payment or variable-rate loans. While this temporarily increased homeownership rates among lower-income demographics, it artificially inflated property prices and accumulated dangerous subprime debt, culminating in severe market crashes and bank failures.

Demand-Side Cash Subsidies and Direct Grants

Direct financial aid and first-time homebuyer subsidies have frequently been used to improve buyer purchasing power. However, when applied to markets with static, unresponsive housing supply, these subsidies simply capitalized into higher market asking prices. Sellers increased prices by the exact amount of the subsidy, leaving ultimate affordability unchanged while increasing total government debt.

Blanket Rent Ceilings

Unconditional rent controls have historically been enacted to shield tenants from steep price increases. Over long periods, strict price ceilings without developer incentives often reduce private sector investment in multi-family housing, cause owners to neglect property maintenance, and reduce the overall quantity of available rental units.

Possible solutions

Solving the housing affordability crisis while mitigating household leverage requires a balanced

mix of supply, regulatory, and financial innovations:

A. Integrated Macroprudential and Lending Regulations

Debt-Service-to-Income (DSTI) Caps: Enforce regulatory ceilings capping monthly total debt servicing at a sustainable percentage (e.g., 30–35%) of gross household income, preventing households from taking on unsustainable borrowing during low-interest periods.

Shared-Equity and Public Co-Investment Models: Implement government or non-profit co-equity programs where public funds cover a percentage of property purchase costs in exchange for a partial equity stake. This reduces mortgage debt burdens and shields low-income buyers from default.

B. Non-Speculative and Alternative Tenure Frameworks

Community Land Trusts (CLTs): Expand CLTs to decouple the value of land from the housing structure built upon it. By holding land in perpetual community ownership and leasing it back affordably, property prices remain insulated from market speculation across generations. Incentivized Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs): Provide tax abatements, municipal land grants, and streamlined permits to developers in exchange for binding guarantees that a fixed share (e.g., 20–40%) of newly constructed units remain permanently affordable.

C. Modernizing Supply and Zoning Frameworks

Reforming Restrictive Zoning: Transition from single-family zoning to higher-density,

transit-oriented zoning (allowing duplexes, triplexes, and accessory dwelling units) to dramatically increase housing supply within existing urban footprints. Adopting Advanced Industrialized Construction: Support modular, prefabricated,

and off-site manufacturing processes to cut construction timelines by 30–50% and lower overall building costs.

Other Relevant Information

Climate Resilience and Energy Poverty

Housing affordability is tied directly to physical climate risks and operating expenses. Low-income families frequently occupy older, poorly insulated homes subject to rising utility costs and extreme weather risks. Integrating energy-efficient designs and renewable building standards into affordable housing construction lowers monthly living costs, improving tenant debt repayment capacity and long-term financial stability.

Growth of Non-Bank Financial Intermediaries (Shadow Banking)

As formal commercial banks face stricter capital rules under frameworks like Basel III and IV, non-bank financial intermediaries—such as private credit funds and online lending platforms—have captured a larger market share in real estate credit. Because these non-bank entities operate with less oversight, monitoring their loan quality is critical to ensuring housing credit risks do not build up outside traditional oversight channels.

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Economic and Financial Affairs Committee

(ECOFIN II)

“Research paper-I”

Council: Economic and Financial Affairs Council (ECOFIN II)

Issue: Addressing the Global Housing Affordability Crisis: Expanding Access to Affordable Housing While Managing Household Debt and Financial Stability Risks

Position: President Chair

Student Officer: Bernadette Bakilana

Introduction of the Topic

Housing affordability has become a significant economic challenge across the world, affecting both developed and developing economies. Rising property prices, increasing rental costs, high construction expenses, and limited access to affordable financing have made it increasingly difficult for households to secure adequate housing without compromising other essential needs. According to UN-Habitat's World Cities Report 2026, approximately 3.4 billion people lack access to secure, safe, and adequate housing. The report highlights the relationship between housing shortages, rapid urbanisation, insufficient investment, economic instability, and displacement. These challenges are particularly pressing in rapidly growing cities, where demand for housing frequently exceeds the available supply. Housing affordability is closely connected to the wider financial system. As property prices rise, households may rely on larger mortgages or other forms of borrowing to purchase homes. Higher interest rates, inflation, and changes in employment or income can make repayments increasingly difficult. Excessive household debt can reduce consumer spending, increase the risk of loan defaults, and expose financial institutions to significant losses. Furthermore, housing markets can become vulnerable to speculative investment, where property is purchased primarily for financial gain rather than residential use. When property prices rise beyond levels supported by household incomes and economic fundamentals, the resulting market correction can threaten household wealth and financial stability. The 2008 global financial crisis demonstrated how problems in housing finance can spread through banks, credit markets, and the wider economy.

Therefore, ECOFIN must consider how governments can expand access to affordable housing

while maintaining responsible lending practices and a stable financial system. Potential approaches include increasing the supply of affordable homes, improving housing finance, strengthening financial regulation, and encouraging cooperation between governments, development banks, and private investors.

The objective is to develop policies that enable households to access safe and affordable housing without creating unsustainable debt or exposing national economies to excessive financial risk.

Definition of Key Terms

● Housing Affordability: The ability of individuals or households to obtain and maintain

adequate housing without placing excessive pressure on their income or preventing them from meeting other essential needs.

● Household Debt: The total amount of money owed by individuals or households through

mortgages, personal loans, credit cards, and other borrowing arrangements.

● Financial Stability: A condition in which financial institutions and markets can continue

functioning effectively and withstand economic shocks without causing widespread disruption.

● Mortgage Lending: The provision of loans to individuals or households to purchase

property, with the property generally serving as collateral for the loan.

● Housing Finance: The financial systems, institutions, and instruments that provide capital

for the construction, purchase, improvement, or rental of housing.

● Housing Speculation: The purchase of property primarily in anticipation of future price

increases, which can contribute to price pressures when speculative demand outpaces the development of housing supply.

● Macroprudential Regulation: Policies designed to reduce risks across the financial

system as a whole, including risks arising from excessive lending, high household indebtedness, and property market instability.

Background of the Issue

The global housing affordability crisis has developed through a combination of economic,

demographic, and financial pressures. Population growth, urbanisation, migration towards employment centres, and changing household structures have increased housing demand. However, the supply of affordable homes has not expanded sufficiently in many areas to meet these needs.

The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), in its 2024 report An

Agenda for Housing Policy Reform, identifies insufficient housing supply in areas with strong demand as a significant contributor to affordability problems. High construction costs, land-use restrictions, limited public investment, and lengthy development processes can further restrict the availability of new housing. The financial consequences are substantial. UN-Habitat reported in its 2026 World Cities Report that 44% of households globally spend more than 30% of their income on housing. Rental

unaffordability is particularly severe in Sub-Saharan Africa, where 55% of renters are classified as overburdened by housing costs. When a large proportion of household income is devoted to rent or mortgage repayments, less money remains available for education, healthcare, food, transportation, and savings.

Access to homeownership also differs considerably between countries. In some economies,

households can access long-term mortgages through established banking systems. In others, high borrowing costs, irregular incomes, limited credit access, and inadequate financial infrastructure make formal housing finance difficult to obtain. Consequently, households may depend on informal housing arrangements, incremental construction, or unregulated lending. Household debt introduces an additional dimension to the crisis. Rising property prices can require buyers to borrow larger amounts relative to their income. If interest rates increase, borrowers with variable-rate mortgages may face higher repayments. Even borrowers with fixed-rate mortgages can experience financial pressure when refinancing becomes more expensive or their household income declines. High household indebtedness can also affect the wider economy. Households facing substantial debt repayments may reduce their consumption, weakening demand for goods and services. If borrowers default on mortgages, banks and other lenders may incur losses. A sharp decline in property prices can worsen these risks by reducing the value of the assets used as loan collateral. The 2008 global financial crisis illustrated these connections. The expansion of risky mortgage lending in the United States, combined with weaknesses in financial products and risk management, contributed to a housing market collapse that spread through international financial markets. Although housing crises differ across countries, this experience demonstrated the importance of responsible lending and effective financial supervision. Developing economies face additional challenges. Rapid urbanisation can increase demand for housing faster than infrastructure and public investment can accommodate. Limited access to long-term, affordable finance may prevent households and developers from meeting this demand. Climate-related disasters can also damage housing stock and increase reconstruction costs, placing additional pressure on households and public budgets. These conditions demonstrate that housing affordability cannot be addressed solely by increasing access to credit. Expanding mortgages without increasing the supply of homes can contribute to higher prices and greater household debt. Conversely, restricting lending too aggressively may prevent creditworthy households and responsible developers from accessing necessary finance. ECOFIN must therefore consider policies that address both the supply of affordable housing and the financial risks associated with housing markets.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue

The international community has introduced several initiatives and policy frameworks relevant to housing affordability, sustainable urban development, and financial stability.

1. Sustainable Development Goal 11

The United Nations Sustainable Development Goals, adopted in 2015, include SDG 11, which

aims to make cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient, and sustainable. Target 11.1 specifically calls for access to adequate, safe, and affordable housing and basic services, alongside the upgrading of slums.

Although this framework establishes international development priorities, implementation

depends on national policies, public investment, institutional capacity, and available financing.

2. The New Urban Agenda

Adopted at the United Nations Conference on Housing and Sustainable Urban Development in 2016, the New Urban Agenda provides a framework for sustainable urbanisation. It encourages governments to promote inclusive urban development, improve housing conditions, strengthen urban planning, and expand access to essential services. However, translating these commitments into affordable homes remains challenging where public funding, land availability, and housing delivery capacity are limited.

3. OECD Housing Policy Reform

The OECD's Brick by Brick: Building Better Housing Policies (2021) and An Agenda for Housing Policy Reform (2024) examine policies affecting housing supply, affordability, taxation, public expenditure, rental markets, and financial regulation. These publications emphasise the importance of coordinated housing policies rather than relying on a single intervention. Their recommendations provide governments with policy approaches that can be adapted to different national circumstances.

4. International Housing Finance Initiatives

UN-Habitat has examined the role of housing finance in expanding access to adequate and

affordable homes. Housing finance mechanisms can help households purchase or improve housing and enable developers to fund construction.

Nevertheless, access to financing alone does not guarantee affordability. Where housing supply is constrained, additional purchasing power may increase property prices rather than improve access. Financial products must therefore be supported by adequate housing supply and appropriate regulation.

5. Financial Regulation Following the 2008 Crisis

Following the global financial crisis, financial regulators strengthened international prudential standards and supervision of banking institutions. These reforms included measures to improve banks' resilience and manage risks associated with lending and financial markets. Such measures are relevant to housing finance because mortgage defaults and property market downturns can threaten financial institutions. However, the effectiveness of financial regulation depends on national implementation, supervisory capacity, and the particular characteristics of domestic housing markets.

Possible Solutions

ECOFIN may consider the following approaches to address the housing affordability crisis while protecting household finances and the wider economy.

1. Expanding the Supply of Affordable Housing

Governments should consider increasing investment in affordable and social housing through public funding, public-private partnerships, and specialised housing providers. Policies could also encourage the use of vacant or underutilised properties where suitable, supported by incentives for owners to make these homes available at affordable rental rates. Investment should be accompanied by adequate infrastructure, including transport, water, sanitation, electricity, and essential public services. Increasing housing supply in locations with employment opportunities can improve access to economic participation while reducing pressure on existing housing markets.

2. Strengthening Responsible Mortgage Lending

Financial regulators should encourage lenders to assess borrowers' ability to repay loans under different economic conditions. Relevant measures may include debt-to-income limits, loan-to-value requirements, affordability assessments, and stress tests that examine how borrowers would cope with higher interest rates or reduced income.

These measures can reduce the risk of excessive borrowing and mortgage defaults. However, implementation should account for differences in income levels and access to credit to avoid unnecessarily excluding lower-income households from formal housing finance.

3. Developing Affordable and Inclusive Housing Finance

Governments and development finance institutions could explore targeted loan guarantees,

concessional financing, and carefully designed mortgage programmes for eligible households and affordable housing developers. Longer repayment periods and appropriately structured financing may improve access to housing by reducing immediate repayment pressures. However, subsidies and guarantees should be transparently funded, carefully targeted, and regularly evaluated to prevent excessive public liabilities or the encouragement of unsustainable borrowing.

4. Increasing Public and Private Investment

Governments could work with multilateral development banks, regional development banks, and private investors to mobilise financing for affordable housing. Funding arrangements should prioritise projects that demonstrate genuine affordability, adequate infrastructure, and long-term financial viability. Public-private partnerships should include clear accountability requirements and safeguards to ensure that publicly supported developments benefit the intended households.

5. Improving Land Use, Planning, and Construction Efficiency

Governments should review planning procedures, land-use regulations, and construction approval processes that unnecessarily delay the development of suitable housing. Where appropriate, they could support higher-density development, mixed-income neighbourhoods, and the redevelopment of underused urban land. Construction innovation and the use of locally available materials may also help reduce costs. Nevertheless, efforts to lower construction expenses should maintain appropriate standards for structural safety, accessibility, environmental performance, and resilience to natural hazards.

6. Strengthening Rental Market Affordability

Governments could explore targeted rental assistance, social housing programmes, and incentives that encourage property owners to offer housing at affordable rates.

Rental policies should aim to protect tenants from severe financial pressure while preserving incentives for the maintenance and construction of rental housing. Regular assessments of local housing conditions can help governments identify which interventions are most appropriate for their markets.

7. Improving Housing Market Transparency

Governments and financial regulators should strengthen the collection and publication of data on housing prices, rents, mortgage lending, household indebtedness, property vacancies, and housing supply. Reliable data would help policymakers identify emerging affordability problems and financial vulnerabilities before they develop into wider crises. Transparent public debt and budget reporting would also help governments evaluate the long-term costs of housing subsidies, guarantees, and publicly financed projects.

8. Promoting International Cooperation

ECOFIN should encourage cooperation between national governments, the IMF, the World Bank, regional development banks, and relevant United Nations agencies. International cooperation could support research, technical assistance, financing mechanisms, and the exchange of effective housing policies. Particular attention should be given to the financing challenges facing developing economies and rapidly urbanising regions. Policy recommendations should remain adaptable to national circumstances because housing shortages, mortgage markets, public resources, and regulatory capacity vary significantly between countries.

Other Relevant Information

One important consideration is the relationship between housing affordability and economic inequality. Households with lower incomes generally have less capacity to absorb increases in rent, mortgage payments, or utility costs. Housing expenses can therefore deepen existing inequalities when they reduce the resources available for education, healthcare, savings, and other essential needs.

Housing affordability also affects economic productivity. When workers cannot afford

accommodation near employment opportunities, they may face longer commutes, higher transportation costs, or barriers to relocating for work. These constraints can reduce labour mobility and limit access to economic opportunities.

Another concern, guys, is the relationship between housing and climate resilience. Floods, storms, and other environmental hazards can damage homes, increase insurance costs, and create additional financial burdens for households and governments. Affordable housing programmes should therefore consider building safety, climate resilience, energy efficiency, and access to essential infrastructure. Furthermore, housing subsidies and government guarantees can create fiscal risks if they are poorly designed. While public intervention may improve housing access, governments must assess the long-term costs of their commitments and ensure that support reaches households who need it. Excessive reliance on public guarantees can transfer financial risks from private lenders to taxpayers.

There’s also a need to distinguish between improving access to homeownership and ensuring

access to adequate housing. Homeownership may not be financially suitable for every household, particularly where incomes are unstable or property prices are exceptionally high. Affordable rental housing, social housing, and secure tenure arrangements can provide alternatives without requiring households to assume large mortgage obligations. Finally, policies must account for differences between developed and developing economies.

Countries with established mortgage markets may focus on lending standards, speculative

investment, and the availability of affordable rental housing. Developing economies may face more immediate challenges involving basic infrastructure, informal settlements, limited access to formal finance, and rapid population growth. ECOFIN should therefore seek an approach that balances housing access, responsible borrowing, sustainable public investment, and financial stability. Effective policies must respond to the underlying causes of unaffordability while reducing the risk that efforts to expand access to housing create new economic vulnerabilities.

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“Research paper-II”

Council: Economic and Financial Affairs Council (ECOFIN).

Issue: Evaluating the Need for Comprehensive Reform of International Sovereign Debt Mechanisms to Address Debt Vulnerability in Developing Economies.

Position: ECOFIN Deputy Chair

Student Officer: Pujitha Shri.H

Introduction of the Topic:

“"Evaluating the Need for Comprehensive Reform of International Sovereign Debt

Mechanisms to Address Debt Vulnerability in Developing Economies” focuses on

examining whether the existing international systems for managing countries debts need major improvements. Developing countries face difficulties in repaying their loans due to high interest rates, currency depreciation, economic crises and natural disasters. These challenges force governments to reduce spending on essentials such as education, healthcare and other important infrastructure. Existing International debt management systems involve institutions such as the

International Monetary Fund (IMF) and the World Bank that help countries manage

financial difficulties. But debt restructuring are slow and complicated due to which they continue facing issues. However, the current debt management system has faced challenges such as slow debt restructuring processes, disagreements between lenders, and including a lack of transparency in some loan agreements. These problems can make it harder for developing countries to recover from debt crises and continue investing in their people's needs. The growing debt problems in developing economies have highlighted the importance of reviewing and improving the existing international sovereign debt system. Reforms such as faster debt restructuring, better cooperation between lenders, clearer loan agreements, and more sustainable repayment plans can help countries manage their debts more effectively.

The aim is to reduce the risk of debt crises while allowing developing countries to

maintain economic stability and continue working towards long-term development.

Definition of Key Terms:

1) International Sovereign Debt Mechanisms: Are the rules and contractual terms

and institutional procedures used to manage or restructure or resolve government

debt when a country struggles to make its scheduled repayments.

2) Debt Vulnerability: The risk that a country cannot sustainably service or

manage, or repay its financial obligations when facing economic shocks, market shifts, or unexpected events

3) International Monetary Fund (IMF):This works to achieve sustainable growth

and prosperity for all of its 191 member countries. It does this by supporting economic policies that promote financial stability and monetary cooperation, which are essential to increase productivity, job creation, and economic well-being

4) Currency Depreciation:

A fall in the value of a country's currency compared with other currencies, which can make foreign-currency debt more expensive to repay

Background of the Issue:

Global debt surged following the 2008 financial crisis and accelerated further through

waves of low-interest-rate borrowing. By 2023, external debt in developing economies reached a record $11.4 trillion (roughly 99% of their export earnings), while total public debt worldwide climbed to $111 trillion (with $35 trillion in low and middle income countries).(Information“https://unctad.org/news/debt-crisis-developing-countries-external -debt-hits-record-4-trillion ”)

Developing countries often have to pay much higher

interest rates on loans than richer countries like the

United States and Germany. This is because lenders

may see them as riskier places to lend money.

This extra cost makes it harder for developing countries

to repay their debts and leaves them with less money to spend on other development needs.

Developing countries borrow money in US dollars instead of their own currency. When

the value of their currency falls or rate of interest rises, they have to pay more money to repay their loans. This makes it harder for them to manage their debts.

These challenges show the need to improve the existing international debt management

system to make debt repayment more manageable, improving cooperation between lenders, and ensuring fair and transparent loan agreements are important steps towards helping developing countries reduce their debt problems and achieve long-term economic growth.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue:

The international community has witnessed several efforts to help developing countries

manage their debts.

Among the initial responses was the Heavily Indebted Poor Countries (HIPC) Initiative to

reduce the debts of poor countries that were struggling to repay, In 1996 brought by IMF and World Bank. In 2005 the Multilateral Debt Relief Initiative (MDRI) was brought to remove certain debts owed by countries that were allowed to join the programme. Moreover, During COVID-19 the Debt Service Suspension Initiative (DSSI) was introduced by the G20 in 2020 which allowed countries that qualified to temporarily stop their debt payments and use the money to deal with urgent needs.

Common Framework was also introduced by the G20 in 2020 to help countries facing

serious debt problems to negotiate with their creditors. It is a close structure similar to the other one. In 2023 the IMF, World Bank and G20 Presidency established the Global Sovereign Debt Roundtable to improve cooperation between countries and lenders.

Possible Solutions:

Developing countries should work together to find solutions to their common debt

problems. The United Nations supported Borrowers' Platform, coordinated by UN Trade and Development (UNCTAD) provides an area for countries to share knowledge, improve debt management and strengthen their collective voice in financial discussions. This helps developing countries participate more effectively in decision making so that it does not affect their economies.

Collective Action Clauses (CACs) should be used more in loan agreements because they

allow a majority of creditors to approve a debt restructuring agreement and prevent a small group from blocking it. Moreover, the G20 Common Framework should be strengthened to improve cooperation between governments and lenders. This helps countries facing debt crises reach agreements in a better way.

Transparency in loan agreements and public debt records can help countries find financial

risks early and also help prevent hidden debts from creating serious problems.

Developing countries should also receive better representation in the IMF and World

Bank, along with better access to affordable loans, debt relief and temporary repayment

help during major economic or climate-related crises. Finally, governments should manage borrowing responsibly and negotiate longer repayment periods when necessary. This would give them more time to repay their debts while continuing to fund developments. Combining these measures could create a fairer and better effective international debt system that better supports developing economies.

Other Relevant Information:

One important issue in international sovereign debt reform is the connection between climate change and debt vulnerability. Developing countries that are affected by floods, droughts and other natural disasters end up needing to borrow more money to rebuild their infrastructure and support their citizens, this increases financial pressure especially when they are already struggling to repay existing loans. UN Trade and Development (UNCTAD) highlights the need to reform international debt systems so that vulnerable countries can access affordable financing while meeting their long-term development needs. Another possible way is the use of debt for development swaps in which creditors agree to reduce or change part of a country's debt obligations in exchange for the government investing in agreed development projects such as education, healthcare or environmental protection. This can help countries direct more resources towards national priorities instead of debt repayments. However, these swaps cannot replace comprehensive debt restructuring when a country's debt is unsustainable. Furthermore, international debt assessments should not only check whether a

country can repay its loans but also check whether it can continue funding essential public services and achieving the Sustainable Development Goals. Debt system that focuses only on repayment places excessive pressure on developing economies. Therefore international institutions should support debt solution that balance financial stability with long term economic growth and human development.

Moreover, lack of a single international legal framework to deal with sovereign debt

crises across all types of creditors is the major problem. Unlike companies, countries cannot simply use one universal bankruptcy process to settle their debts. As a result, negotiations often depend on separate agreements between governments and international

institutions and private lenders making the process complicated. Poorly designed reforms will create different hazards which occur when governments or lenders take greater financial risks because they expect to receive assistance if any problems arise. If debt relief is repeatedly provided without clear conditions some governments can become less careful about borrowing, while lenders may pay less attention to the risks of their loans.

Another risk is unequal treatment among developing countries. If international

institutions give more generous support to certain countries than others countries facing similar financial difficulties this can receive different outcomes. This can weaken trust in the international financial system and make future negotiations more difficult. Clear eligibility rules and consistent procedures are more important.

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Political Council

(PC)

“Research paper-I”

Council: Political Council

Issue: Redefining the Legitimacy of Political and Economic Pressure in International Relations

Position: President Chair

Student Officer: Abdullah Bin Imran

Introduction

In the twenty-first century, dynamics of international relations and conflicts have shifted greatly from traditional, man-to-man military violence to systematic, non-kinetic instruments of power and manipulation. States employ sanctions, financial blockades and--in cases of military violence--indirect tools of war such as drones to compel behavioral or institutional changes in sovereign states. While these tools are frequently framed as necessary, their application has become a novel obstacle which flanks the content of debates regarding legitimacy and ethical boundaries.

The international system operates based on core principles of political independence, right to rule, and non-intervention. This council, therefore, is burdened with balancing the sovereignty of nations to practice their own sovereignty by establishing financial or political techniques such as sanctions, while preventing this as becoming a threat for the economies and independence of the victimized nations.

The Political Council must evaluate where the boundary lies between modern, authorized diplomatic leverage, and illegitimate coercion, intervention and manipulation.

Definition of Key Terms

Political and Economic Pressure: Techniques used by nations in terms of political orders or economic changes to pressurize other nations to conform or adapt their own rulings away from their interest

Political Coercion: Use of diplomatic threats political maneuvers, etc by one nation to force another to alter its foreign policies

Sanctions: Punitive measures and penalties put into place by countries on other nations for violating international regulations Secondary Sanctions: Penalties applied by sanctioning countries against third-party foreign individuals, companies or states for engaging in trade with a primary targeted state

Sovereignty and Non-intervention: Right of each nation to possess exclusive authority over their territory and domestic affairs without external influence, as outlined by the UN charter, Article 2

Background of Issue

Following WWII, the UN Security Council was established as the legally empowered body to apply collective sanctions. During the early post-Cold War era, sanctions were primarily multilateral and designed to prevent aggression and nuclear proliferation.

However, over the past 2 decades, the globe has seen a sharp increase in unilateral pressure tactics. The UNSC has been unable to encourage agreements on major global crises due to vetoes, and this has pushed certain individual states to circumvent the UN framework.

Secondary sanction have been widely deployed, forcing third-party nations to choose between complying or risking access to global markets.

Simultaneously, state tactics have evolved beyond traditional economic measures. Cyber threats, foreign investments and supply chain manipulation are all but a few techniques commonly exploited. This has blurred the line between legitimate and necessary international intervention, and an illegal breach of a nation's soverignty.

Consequently, many developing nations argue that economic pressure tactics disproportionately burden vulnerable civilian populations while failing to achieve their stated political or policy objectives.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue

Multiple steps have been taken by the international community to address legitimacy and legality regarding the issue:

UN General Assembly Resolutions: The UNGA has repeatedly passed resolutions condemning Unilateral Coercive Measures (UCMs) and highlighting that non-mandated sanctions undermine soverignty and human rights. Annual resolutions have called for elimination of economic measures which unilaterally target and disrupt developing nations' political landscape.

Transition to "Smart Sanctions": In response to humanitarian crises rooted in this issue in the 1990s, the intenrational community shifted towards targeted sanctions specifically to hold governemtns or individuals accountable while shielding the public (such as asset freezes, travel bans, etc)

Development of Alternative Financial Mechanisms: Nations targeted by or opposed to unilateral sanctions have established independent financial platforms, alternative messaging systems, and bilateral currency settlement channels to mitigate the impact of foreign economic leverage.

Despite efforts, political divisions have prevented consensus on a binding legal framework

Possible Solutions

To establish a legal, balanced and enforceable consensus, this council must NOT re-exert already agreed upon claims and resolutions regarding the illegitimacy of intervention, but rather clearly define a boundary and set novel frameworks to preserve sovereignty while maintaining the UN's right to establish coercive measures.

This may be done by:

Establishing Clear UN Rules on Coercive Measures Regulating Secondary Sanctions

Institutionalizing and Regulating Humanitarian Exemptions

Improving Transparency

Additional Information

The challenge of defining political and economic pressure is deeply tied to the ongoing transition toward a multipolar world order. As emerging economies gain influence, traditional sanction regimes face increasing resistance. Ultimately, the Political Council must balance sovereign rights of ALL states to protect national interests and international law. It is imperative we safeguard human rights and the global economic landscape while maintain a stable global order.

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“Research paper-II”

Council: Political Council

Issue: Regulating the Growing Influence of Private Technology Companies In National Governance and Security

Position: Deputy Chair

Student Officer: Katalina Nalwadda

Introduction of the Topic

In recent years, legal administration and governance have shifted from being exclusively held by the state to being largely held by private corporations. With the rising use of the Internet of Things and Artificial Intelligence being integrated into everyday life, the power of private technology companies has grown exponentially beyond research and development and has become a severe threat to state sovereignty and security While technological advancement in a country is often seen as a fundamental part of economic and social development, it reduces state autonomy and decision-making. A single conglomerate can now develop and sell algorithms that are able to affect electoral processes, which have contributed to the undermining of state control. The planning and implementation of mandates to control the power such companies have-such as the European Union Artificial Intelligence Act (EU AI Act)-have been at the forefront of political discussions over the past years to reinstate national sovereignty and governmental power

Definition of key terms

Technology Sovereignty - A state's ability to control its digital space, protect national data, and run critical software without complete dependence on foreign companies. Platform Governance - The internal rules, moderation choices, and code that private companies use to direct online speech and public debate. Algorithmic Curation - The background systems that rank and push online content based on user engagement, directly shaping public opinion. Regulatory Arbitrage - The tactic of moving operations across borders to exploit weak laws and avoid government oversight. Dual-Use Commercial Tech - Civilian tech products such as cloud platforms, satellite fleets, and AI models that can be repurposed for military or intelligence operations. Westphalian Sovereignty - The traditional legal idea that a nation-state is able to have full control over its territory, laws, borders and national security. Lex informatica - It refers to the set of rules, norms, and behavioral constraints imposed on individuals through technology, network design, and system configurations rather than traditional state-enacted laws.

Background information

Historically, many nation-states exercised Westphalian Sovereignty over their countries. It ensured they had complete control over the politics and security of their own country without external interference. This allowed nation-states to monopolise key public functions and services such as infrastructure and law enforcement. However, with the rise of transnational “tech titans”, this governance has now changed. As private corporations develop more essential digital infrastructure, the boundaries of the more traditional Westphalian Sovereignty become increasingly blurred. This forces governmental bodies to compete with private entities for sovereign authority.

This shift has stemmed from the corporate ownership of critical digital infrastructure such as fibre-optic cables or Artificial Intelligence data centres. Unlike the aforementioned key functions, such as roads, owned by the state, digital infrastructure is not a public utility but is instead a privately owned asset. As a consequence, the terms and conditions of these private corporations act as a form of private governance, also known as Lex informatica. This regulates public discourse and data security without needing democratic oversight.

In response to the shifting power balance, governments and international bodies, such as the United Nations Independent International Scientific Panel on Artificial Intelligence and the Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (IEEE), are actively trying to restore national sovereignty through comprehensive legal frameworks rather than allowing privately owned companies to continue exercising such power. An example of this is the Council of Europe Framework Convention on AI and Human Rights, Democracy and Rule of Law (2024), which was established and passed by the Council of Europe Committee of Ministers. Such legislative action marks a pivotal transition in the mitigation of the loss of state-run nations. Such interventions reflect a global movement towards digital sovereignty in which democratic states aim to regain control over critical digital infrastructure and ensure that private technology serves the public interest rather than corporate dominance.

Previous attempts to solve the issue

In the past, states depended on traditional antitrust enforcement to mitigate the effects of corporate overreach by treating such firms through the lens of consumer harm. As a result, high-profile legal battles, such as the United States

government’s 1998 antitrust suit against Microsoft, along with recent Federal Trade Commission actions against Google and Meta, have attempted to challenge monopolistic market positions. However, this was fundamentally unsuited for modern digital ecosystems. Additionally, big tech firms often offer products with zero direct cost in exchange for user data, which traditional antitrust enforcement fails to account for.

Governments were able to recognise that user data is a core asset for many large technology companies and, as a result, pivoted to protecting user data, most notably through the European Union’s General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) established in 2018. This sought to establish state sovereignty by framing data rights as basic human rights, imposing strict consequences and financial penalties for deviance. While it was successful in shifting global norms around digital privacy, it highlighted the limitations of attempting to curb corporate powers, as large corporations were able to easily absorb compliance costs and repurpose their legal teams, whereas smaller firms struggled to do so. Ultimately, it failed to restrict the acquisition of critical digital infrastructure such as cloud data centres.

Possible solutions

There are many possible solutions for this urgent global issue, such as:

To reduce dependency on private technology conglomerates, nation states are investing in officially endorsed digital infrastructure and Sovereign AI. Rather than relying exclusively on foreign corporations for cloud computing and advanced language models, governments are funding open source national AI models and public data networks Governments are also adopting ex-ante regulatory frameworks to further enforce accountability before technology is deployed to the public Sovereign states are employing strict data localisation mandates to reinforce control of their own digital spaces

Other relevant information

The Brussels effect explains that when major regional markets (Mainly the European Union) enact strict technology regulations, Transnational Tech Corporations often adopt those rules globally Global initiatives like the UN's Global Digital Compact, which was adopted in late 2024, attempt to balance corporate innovation with democratic accountability by bringing governments, tech conglomerates, and civil society to the same table

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Special Political and Decolonization Committee

(SPECPOL)

“Research paper-I”

Council: Special Political and Decolonization Committee (SPECPOL)

Issue: Examining the Principles of Self-Determination and the Political

Status of Non-Self-Governing Territories in the Contemporary International Order.

Position: President Chair

Student Officer: Aliakbar Moledina

Executive Summary

This research document examines the evolution, legal frameworks, and

contemporary challenges surrounding the principle of self-determination and the political status of Non-Self-Governing Territories (NSGTs) under international law. While decolonization was one of the central achievements of the 20th century under United Nations auspices, 17 Non-Self-Governing Territories remain globally today, representing millions of inhabitants seeking defined governance paths.

1. Conceptual and Legal Frameworks of Self-Determination

Definition & Evolution

The right of self-determination has evolved from a political

principle—prominently articulated in post-World War I diplomatic arrangements—into a peremptory norm (jus cogens) of international law. It establishes the legal right of peoples to determine their own political status and pursue their economic, social, and cultural development. UN Charter Foundations

● Chapter XI (Articles 73–74): Contains the Declaration Regarding

Non-Self-Governing Territories. It binds administering Powers to recognize that the interests of the inhabitants of these territories are paramount, obligating states to accept a "sacred trust" to promote their well-being and advance self-government.

● Chapters XII & XIII: Established the International Trusteeship System

to supervise trust territories. This system successfully concluded its mandate following the independence of Palau in 1994. Key UN Resolutions

● UNGA Resolution 1514 (XV) (1960): The Declaration on the Granting

of Independence to Colonial Countries and Peoples, declaring that all peoples have an inalienable right to complete freedom and the exercise of their sovereignty.

● UNGA Resolution 1541 (XV) (1960): Defines the criteria for

determining whether an obligation exists to transmit information under Article 73(e) and establishes the three legitimate options for full

self-government:

○ Emergence as a sovereign independent State. ○ Free association with an independent State. ○ Integration with an independent State.

● UNGA Resolution 2625 (XXV) (1970): The Declaration on Principles

of International Law concerning Friendly Relations, which codified self-determination as a foundational rule of international jurisprudence while explicitly balancing it against the principles of territorial integrity.

2. Internal vs. External Self-Determination

External Self-Determination

Refers to the right of a distinct population or territorial group to establish its legal status vis-à-vis the international community. This encompasses the options defined in Resolution 1541 (XV), namely achieving full independence, entering into a free association agreement with an existing nation, or fully integrating into a sovereign state.

Internal Self-Determination

Encompasses the right of a population to freely pursue its political, economic,

social, and cultural development within the framework of an existing sovereign state. It emphasizes participatory democracy, local autonomy, respect for human rights, and constitutional arrangements that allow minority groups equitable representation. Remedial Secession

An ongoing doctrine and legal debate concerning whether a distinct sub-state

population subjected to systematic oppression, gross human rights violations, or total denial of internal self-determination possesses a secondary right to unilateral secession under extraordinary circumstances under international law.

3. Overview of Current Non-Self-Governing Territories (NSGTs)

As monitored by the United Nations Special Committee on Decolonization

(C-24), 17 territories remain classified as Non-Self-Governing:

Region Territory Administering Power Africa Western Sahara De facto administrative zone Atlantic & Caribbean Anguilla United Kingdom Bermuda United Kingdom British Virgin Islands United Kingdom Cayman Islands United Kingdom Falkland Islands United Kingdom (Malvinas)

Region Territory Administering Power Montserrat United Kingdom Saint Helena United Kingdom Turks and Caicos Islands United Kingdom

United States Virgin United States

Islands

Pacific American Samoa United States

French Polynesia France

Guam United States

New Caledonia France Pitcairn United Kingdom Tokelau New Zealand

4. Key Challenges & Contemporary Debates

Sovereignty Disputes vs. Inhabitants' Will

Significant tensions frequently emerge between state claims grounded in historic territorial integrity and the democratically expressed wishes of territorial residents. High-profile examples include the competing sovereignty claims over the Falkland Islands (Malvinas), Gibraltar, and the enduring geopolitical complexity surrounding Western Sahara.

Economic Viability and Small Island States

The majority of remaining NSGTs are small island developing environments facing unique macroeconomic vulnerabilities. These territories encounter structural constraints including narrow economic bases, high exposure to climate-induced environmental threats, limited administrative capacity, and heavy reliance on external financial transfers or fiscal privileges.

Institutional Role of the United Nations

Questions persist regarding the mandate efficiency and diplomatic mechanisms of the UN General Assembly, the Fourth Committee (Special Political and

Decolonization), and the Special Committee of 24 (C-24). Key debates center

on updating criteria for de-listing territories and enhancing direct engagement with local elected leadership.

5. Conclusion and Recommendations

● Enhance Monitoring & Mission Access: Reinforce transparent, periodic

consultations and re-establish regular UN visiting missions to NSGTs to ensure objective assessment of local socioeconomic and political conditions.

● Support Structural Resilience: Tailor international legal and economic

support frameworks specifically to bolster the climate adaptation capacities and fiscal stability of small island territories.

● Reconcile Legal Frameworks: Maintain balanced, continuous

diplomatic mechanisms capable of mediating the tension between sovereign state claims of territorial integrity and the legitimate self-determination rights of territorial inhabitants.

“Research paper-II”

Council: Special Political and Decolonization Committee (SPECPOL)

Issue: Addressing the Unresolved Question of Self-Determination in Western Sahara and the Role of the United Nations

Position: Deputy Chair

Student Officer: Liyaan Karbelkar

1. Introduction to the Topic

The question of self-determination in Western Sahara remains one of the longest-standing

unresolved issues of decolonization before the United Nations. Located in northwestern Africa along the Atlantic coast, Western Sahara borders Morocco to the north, Algeria to the northeast and Mauritania to the east and south. Its territory includes extensive desert regions and a coastline with valuable fisheries. Despite its relatively small population, Western Sahara has remained the subject of a prolonged political and territorial dispute involving competing claims to sovereignty, the rights of the Sahrawi people, and the role of international law in resolving conflicts inherited from colonial rule. Western Sahara was colonized by Spain in the late nineteenth century and remained under Spanish administration for nearly a century. As the process of decolonization advanced across Africa during the 20th century, the territory's future became increasingly contested. Morocco maintained that Western Sahara had historical ties to the Moroccan monarchy, while Mauritania also advanced claims based on historical and cultural connections. These positions were opposed by the Polisario Front, a Sahrawi liberation movement established in 1973, which called for an end to Spanish colonial rule and the Sahrawi people's right to determine their own political future. The dispute intensified in 1975, when the International Court of Justice issued an advisory opinion on the territory's legal status. Although the Court recognized certain historical ties of allegiance between the Moroccan Sultan and some tribes in Western Sahara, it did not find ties of territorial sovereignty sufficient to override the principle of self-determination. In the same year, Spain, Morocco and Mauritania signed the Madrid Accords, and Morocco organized the Green March, during which large numbers of Moroccan civilians entered the territory. Spain subsequently withdrew, but the departure of the colonial administration did not result in an agreed process through which the Sahrawi population could determine the territory's future. Instead, armed conflict developed between the Polisario Front and the forces of Morocco and Mauritania. Mauritania withdrew from the conflict and renounced its claim in 1979, after which Morocco extended its control over the area it had previously administered. The United Nations became increasingly involved in efforts to end the conflict and establish a political settlement. In 1991, following negotiations between Morocco and the Polisario

Front, the Security Council established the United Nations Mission for the Referendum in

Western Sahara (MINURSO). The settlement plan was intended to provide for a ceasefire

and a referendum through which the people of Western Sahara could choose their future status. However, disagreements over voter eligibility, the referendum process and the

political outcome prevented the vote from taking place. Although the ceasefire generally held for almost three decades, it broke down in November 2020, and hostilities resumed at a low intensity.

Today, the central disagreement remains unresolved. Morocco proposes autonomy for

Western Sahara under Moroccan sovereignty, while the Polisario Front continues to

advocate for self-determination that includes the possibility of independence. The United Nations continues to regard Western Sahara as a Non-Self-Governing Territory, and

MINURSO remains deployed. Security Council Resolution 2797, adopted on 31 October

2025, renewed the Mission's mandate until 31 October 2026 and called for negotiations taking Morocco's autonomy proposal as their basis, while referring to a political solution that provides for the self-determination of the people of Western Sahara. The dispute therefore remains closely connected to decolonization, territorial sovereignty, regional security, humanitarian needs and the interpretation of the right to self-determination.

2. Definition of Key Terms

● Self-determination: The principle that peoples have the right to determine their

political status and pursue their economic, social and cultural development. In the context of Western Sahara, the disagreement concerns how this right should be exercised and what political outcomes must be available to the Sahrawi people.

● Decolonization: The process through which a territory under colonial rule moves towards a political status determined in accordance with the rights of its people. The United Nations identifies Western Sahara as a Non-Self-Governing Territory whose decolonization remains incomplete.

● Non-Self-Governing Territory: A territory whose people have not yet attained a full measure of self-government, as described in Chapter XI of the United Nations Charter. Western Sahara has been on the UN list of Non-Self-Governing Territories since 1963.

● Sahrawi people: The people indigenous to Western Sahara, with communities living in the territory and in neighbouring countries, including refugee camps near Tindouf in Algeria. The Sahrawi population is not politically uniform, and views on the territory's future should not be assumed to be identical among all individuals.

● Polisario Front: The Popular Front for the Liberation of Saguia el-Hamra and Río de Oro, founded in 1973. It initially fought against Spanish colonial rule and subsequently against Moroccan and Mauritanian forces. It represents the independence movement in the Western Sahara dispute and proclaimed the Sahrawi Arab Democratic Republic in 1976.

● Sahrawi Arab Democratic Republic (SADR): A state proclaimed by the Polisario Front on 27 February 1976. It is recognized by some states and is a member of the African Union. Its claim to statehood and the status of Western Sahara remain disputed internationally.

● Territorial sovereignty: The authority of a state over a territory. Morocco claims sovereignty over Western Sahara, while the Polisario Front disputes Moroccan sovereignty and seeks a process of self-determination.

● Autonomy: A political arrangement in which a territory exercises a degree of self-government while remaining within a larger sovereign state. Morocco's 2007 proposal offers autonomy for Western Sahara under Moroccan sovereignty.

● Referendum: A direct vote in which eligible voters decide a political question. The UN settlement plan for Western Sahara envisaged a referendum on the territory's future, but disagreements over voter eligibility and implementation prevented it from being held.

● MINURSO: The United Nations Mission for the Referendum in Western Sahara, established by Security Council Resolution 690 in April 1991. Its original mandate was connected to the settlement plan and referendum, and its current work includes monitoring the security situation, observing military developments and supporting efforts to reduce tensions.

● Ceasefire: An agreement or arrangement to halt armed hostilities. The 1991 ceasefire between Morocco and the Polisario Front generally held until November 2020, when the Polisario Front announced that it no longer considered itself bound by it.

● Berm: A long sand-and-earth defensive barrier built by Morocco during the war. It separates areas under Moroccan control from areas to the east and south where the Polisario Front operates. The area around the berm contains landmines and explosive remnants of war.

● Madrid Accords: The Declaration of Principles on Western Sahara signed by Spain, Morocco and Mauritania on 14 November 1975. It arranged for Spain's withdrawal and the transfer of administrative responsibilities, but it did not settle the question of self-determination or resolve the territory's final international status.

● International Court of Justice (ICJ): The principal judicial organ of the United Nations. In October 1975, it issued an advisory opinion on the legal status of Western Sahara before Spanish colonization and the historical ties between the territory and Morocco and Mauritania.

● United Nations Security Council (UNSC): The UN organ with primary responsibility for maintaining international peace and security. It has adopted resolutions on Western Sahara, established MINURSO and renewed its mandate.

● Fourth Committee: The Special Political and Decolonization Committee of the UN General Assembly. It considers issues including decolonization and Non-Self-Governing Territories. SPECPOL debates these matters and makes recommendations to the General Assembly; it does not independently command peacekeeping missions or impose a settlement on the parties.

3. Background Information

3.1 Before and During Spanish Colonial Rule

Western Sahara is part of the Sahara region of northwestern Africa. Before European colonization, the area was inhabited by Sahrawi communities whose social, political and economic life was shaped by tribal relationships, pastoralism, trade and movement across desert routes. Communities had connections with neighbouring regions, including present-day Morocco, Mauritania and Algeria. These historical connections later became important in competing claims over the territory, but they did not mean that Western Sahara

had been governed as a modern, territorially defined sovereign state in the same way as contemporary states. Spain began establishing a colonial presence along the coast in 1884, during the period of European colonial expansion in Africa. Its control gradually developed over the area that became known as Spanish Sahara, commonly divided into Saguia el-Hamra in the north and Río de Oro in the south. Spain consolidated its colonial administration during the 20th century and, in 1958, formally organized Spanish Sahara as a Spanish province. The broader process of African decolonization following the Second World War changed the political context. Many territories under European colonial rule gained independence, and the United Nations increasingly addressed the rights of colonized peoples. Morocco regained independence from France and Spain in 1956 and subsequently argued that Western Sahara should be reunited with Morocco. Mauritania became independent in 1960 and also advanced a claim to the territory. Spain, meanwhile, continued administering Western Sahara. In 1963, the United Nations included Spanish Sahara on its list of Non-Self-Governing Territories. The General Assembly subsequently adopted resolutions calling for decolonization and for the population to exercise self-determination. Resolution 2229 (XXI), adopted in 1966, called for a referendum under UN auspices. However, disagreement over the territory's political future and the competing positions of Spain, Morocco and Mauritania complicated efforts to arrange such a vote.

3.2 The Emergence of the Polisario Front

The Polisario Front was founded on 10 May 1973 by Sahrawi activists seeking to end

Spanish colonial rule. It initially pursued the goal of independence from Spain and began

armed action against the colonial administration. As Spain's withdrawal became more likely, the movement increasingly opposed Moroccan and Mauritanian claims to the territory.

In 1974, Spain announced plans to conduct a referendum on self-determination. The

proposed vote did not take place. The General Assembly requested an advisory opinion from the International Court of Justice to clarify the territory's legal status and its historical relationships with Morocco and Mauritania. The question of self-determination had therefore become both a decolonization issue and a dispute over competing interpretations of history and sovereignty.

3.3 The International Court of Justice Advisory Opinion, 1975

On 16 October 1975, the International Court of Justice delivered its advisory opinion on

Western Sahara. The Court concluded that the territory had not been terra nullius (a territory belonging to no one) at the time Spain colonized it. It found that there had been legal ties of allegiance between the Moroccan Sultan and some tribes in the territory, as well as certain rights relating to land between the territory and the Mauritanian entity. However, the Court did not find that these ties established territorial sovereignty by Morocco or Mauritania over Western Sahara. It concluded that the findings did not affect the

application of the principle of self-determination through the free and genuine expression of the will of the people of the territory. The opinion did not award Western Sahara to Morocco or Mauritania, nor did it itself determine the territory's final political status. The opinion became a central reference point in the dispute. Morocco emphasized the historical ties identified by the Court, while the Polisario Front and supporters of independence emphasized the Court's conclusion that these ties did not displace the right of the people to self-determination.

3.4 The Green March and the Madrid Accords, 1975

In November 1975, Morocco organized the Green March, during which approximately 350,000 Moroccan civilians entered the area near Western Sahara's northern border. The march was intended to demonstrate Morocco's claim to the territory. It took place shortly after the ICJ advisory opinion and during a period of political uncertainty in Spain, whose leader Francisco Franco was seriously ill and died later that month. On 14 November 1975, Spain, Morocco and Mauritania signed the Madrid Accords, also known as the Declaration of Principles on Western Sahara. The agreement provided for Spain's withdrawal and a temporary arrangement involving Moroccan and Mauritanian administration. The Polisario Front was not a party to the agreement, and the accords did not resolve the question of self-determination. Spain ended its presence in Western Sahara in early 1976. Morocco took control of much of the northern and central parts of the territory, while Mauritania administered the southern portion. The change in administration was followed by armed conflict between the Polisario Front and the forces of Morocco and Mauritania. Many Sahrawi civilians fled the fighting, with a significant number settling in refugee camps near Tindouf in southwestern Algeria. On 27 February 1976, as Spain's withdrawal was completed, the Polisario Front proclaimed the Sahrawi Arab Democratic Republic. The SADR became a political institution associated with the independence movement and later gained recognition from a number of states.

3.5 The War Between the Polisario Front, Morocco and Mauritania, 1976–1991

The armed conflict expanded after Spain's withdrawal. The Polisario Front fought both Morocco and Mauritania, using their mobile and stealthy military tactics across the desert. Morocco sought to maintain control over the territory it administered, while Mauritania struggled with the economic and military costs of the conflict.

In 1979, Mauritania signed an agreement with the Polisario Front and renounced its

territorial claim. It withdrew from the part of Western Sahara it had administered. Morocco subsequently extended its control over that area. The conflict therefore became primarily a confrontation between Morocco and the Polisario Front. During the 1980s, Morocco constructed a series of defensive earthworks and sand barriers, commonly known as the berm. The barrier, together with military positions and minefields, helped Morocco consolidate control over the more populated and economically important western portion of the territory, including major towns and much of the Atlantic coastline. The

Polisario Front operated mainly in areas east and south of the berm and from bases in Algeria. The barrier remains a major physical and military feature of the dispute.

The war caused displacement, family separation and long-term insecurity. Sahrawi refugees

in Algeria developed communities and political institutions in the camps near Tindouf, where humanitarian assistance became important for food, healthcare, education and other essential services. Meanwhile, people living in the territory remained affected by the conflict and by the competing political claims. The Organization of African Unity (OAU), the predecessor of the African Union, became involved in diplomatic efforts to resolve the dispute. International concern increasingly focused on achieving a ceasefire and creating a process through which the territory's political future could be decided. After years of fighting, the parties accepted UN-OAU settlement proposals in 1988.

3.6 The 1991 Settlement Plan and Establishment of MINURSO

In 1988, Morocco and the Polisario Front accepted settlement proposals developed through

UN and OAU efforts. The proposals included a ceasefire and a transitional process leading

to a referendum on the future of Western Sahara. In 1990, the Security Council endorsed the settlement plan, and on 29 April 1991 it adopted Resolution 690, establishing MINURSO. The ceasefire took effect in September 1991. The referendum was initially expected to take place in early 1992. MINURSO was tasked with supporting the implementation of the settlement plan, including identifying eligible voters, monitoring the ceasefire and assisting with the referendum process. The process of identifying eligible voters became one of the main obstacles. The parties disagreed over which Sahrawis should be entitled to vote, including how to interpret the Spanish colonial census and how to consider applications by people whose eligibility was contested. These disagreements had major political consequences because the referendum's outcome could determine whether Western Sahara became independent or remained under Moroccan sovereignty.

MINURSO's Identification Commission began identifying potential voters in 1994. The

process encountered extensive disputes and challenges. In May 1996, the UN suspended the identification process and withdrew most civilian staff involved in the referendum preparations. The Mission's military component remained in place to monitor the ceasefire. Although the referendum never took place, the UN continued to maintain a presence and to seek a political settlement.

3.7 Attempts to Revive the Settlement Process, 1997–2004

In the late 1990s, the UN pursued further negotiations to address the implementation problems. The Houston Agreements of 1997, reached with the assistance of UN Special

Envoy James Baker, sought to resolve disagreements over voter identification, appeals and

other elements of the referendum process. Although the agreements helped advance parts of the process, disputes continued and the referendum remained unimplemented. In 2001, Baker presented a framework for a political solution that would provide for a period of autonomy for Western Sahara within Morocco, followed by a referendum. The proposal

faced opposition from the Polisario Front, which argued that the framework did not adequately protect the Sahrawi people's right to choose independence. In 2003, a revised proposal, commonly known as the Baker Plan or Baker Plan II, proposed a transitional period of autonomy followed by a referendum that would include options concerning the territory's final status. The Polisario Front accepted the plan, while Morocco rejected it. The Security Council supported efforts to find a mutually acceptable political solution but the plan was not implemented. By the mid-2000s, the original referendum process had effectively stalled. The international community continued to recognize self-determination as a central principle in the dispute, but there was no agreement on the process or political options through which it could be achieved.

3.8 Proposals and Negotiations Since 2007

In 2007, Morocco submitted an autonomy proposal to the United Nations. Under this proposal, Western Sahara would exercise local self-government in areas such as administration, economic development and certain social affairs, while Morocco would retain sovereignty and responsibility for areas including defence, foreign affairs and currency. Morocco

has described the proposal as a basis for a negotiated political settlement. The Polisario Front also submitted a proposal in 2007, emphasizing a referendum on self-determination that would allow the Sahrawi people to choose among political outcomes, including independence. The two proposals reflected fundamentally different understandings of what a final settlement should provide: Morocco's proposal would maintain the territory within the Moroccan state, while the Polisario Front's position retained independence as an available outcome. The Security Council called for negotiations without preconditions and for a just, lasting and mutually acceptable political solution that would provide for the self-determination of the people of Western Sahara. UN-sponsored talks were held in 2007 and 2008, followed by informal meetings in later years. These discussions did not resolve the main differences between the parties.

3.9 The 2010 Gdeim Izik Events and Human Rights Concerns

In October 2010, a protest camp known as Gdeim Izik was established near Laayoune, the largest city in Western Sahara. Participants raised social and economic grievances, including concerns about housing, employment and access to resources, alongside wider political issues. Moroccan security forces dismantled the camp in November 2010, leading to clashes and deaths among civilians and security personnel. The events attracted international attention and intensified debate over human rights, political freedoms and the treatment of Sahrawis in the territory. The Gdeim Izik events did not resolve the dispute's central political question. However, they became part of broader international discussion about conditions in Western Sahara, the rights of residents, and the difficulties of separating social and economic grievances from the unresolved question of sovereignty.

3.10 The Guerguerat Crisis and Breakdown of the Ceasefire, 2020

For almost three decades after the 1991 ceasefire, large-scale hostilities were largely avoided, although the political settlement remained unresolved. In October 2020, Sahrawi civilians and activists blocked a road near Guerguerat, in the southern part of Western Sahara near the Mauritanian border. The area is strategically important because it is used for road transport and trade between Morocco-controlled Western Sahara and Mauritania. In November 2020, Moroccan forces moved to clear the roadblock. The Polisario Front announced that the ceasefire had ended and declared a return to armed struggle. Since then, military incidents and exchanges of fire have been reported, although the hostilities have generally remained at a lower intensity than the earlier war.

MINURSO has continued to monitor the security situation and report on military

developments. The Mission has also supported mine-action activities to reduce risks from landmines and explosive remnants of war. The breakdown of the ceasefire weakened one of the principal achievements of the 1991 settlement plan and increased the urgency of renewed diplomatic efforts.

3.11 Developments in 2021–2026

Following the resumption of hostilities, the UN continued diplomatic consultations through the Secretary-General's Personal Envoy. Staffan de Mistura was appointed to the role in

2021. His work has included consultations with Morocco, the Polisario Front, Algeria and

Mauritania, as well as with UN Member States. Efforts to restart a substantive political

process have remained difficult because the parties continue to disagree over the framework for negotiations and the meaning of self-determination in a final settlement. Morocco has continued to promote its 2007 autonomy proposal as the basis for negotiations.

The Polisario Front has maintained that a genuine process of self-determination must

include the possibility of independence. In October 2025, the Polisario Front also presented an expanded proposal that it said could allow consideration of an autonomy arrangement if it were accepted by the Sahrawi population through a referendum that also included independence as an option. The parties have not reached agreement on a common framework for a final settlement.

On 31 October 2025, the Security Council adopted Resolution 2797, renewing MINURSO's

mandate until 31 October 2026. The resolution called for negotiations taking Morocco's autonomy proposal as their basis, with the stated objective of reaching a just, lasting and mutually acceptable solution that provides for the self-determination of the people of Western Sahara. It also recognized that genuine autonomy could represent a feasible outcome and encouraged the parties to submit constructive ideas. The resolution passed with 11 votes in favour, no votes against and three abstentions; Algeria did not participate in the vote.

The resolution marked an important development in the diplomatic framework supported by

the Security Council, but it did not itself settle the status of Western Sahara. The fundamental differences over sovereignty, independence, autonomy and the process of self-determination remain. MINURSO's mandate continues through October 2026, and the

question of how the UN mission and political process should develop remains closely connected to the progress of negotiations.

4. Previous Attempts to Resolve the Issue

● United Nations General Assembly Resolutions

● From the 1960s onwards, the General Assembly repeatedly addressed Spanish

Sahara as a Non-Self-Governing Territory and called for decolonization. Resolutions including 2229 (XXI) in 1966 called for a referendum under UN auspices. The General Assembly also requested the ICJ advisory opinion in 1974 and continued to consider Western Sahara after Spain's withdrawal.

● These resolutions established the UN's longstanding involvement in the issue and

reinforced the connection between the territory's political future and decolonization. However, General Assembly resolutions did not produce an agreed referendum or final settlement.

● The Madrid Accords, 1975

● The Madrid Accords arranged Spain's withdrawal and the transfer of administrative

responsibilities to Morocco and Mauritania. Because the Polisario Front was not a party and the accords did not settle self-determination, they changed the territory's administration without resolving its final status.

● The 1988 Settlement Proposals and the 1991 Plan

● The proposals accepted by Morocco and the Polisario Front offered a ceasefire and

referendum, and Security Council Resolution 690 established MINURSO to support implementation. The ceasefire reduced direct fighting for almost three decades, but disagreements over voter eligibility prevented the referendum from taking place.

● The Houston Agreements, 1997

● Facilitated by UN Special Envoy James Baker, the agreements sought to resolve

disputes over voter identification and appeals. They helped advance parts of the process, but disagreements over eligibility and implementation remained, and the referendum was not held.

● The Baker Plans, 2001 and 2003

● The 2001 proposal offered autonomy within Morocco followed by a referendum. The

revised 2003 plan proposed transitional autonomy followed by a vote on final status; the Polisario Front accepted it, while Morocco rejected it. Its failure illustrates how a framework can combine competing approaches yet remain unimplemented without agreement from the parties.

● Negotiations Following the 2007 Proposals

● The parties submitted competing proposals in 2007, and UN-sponsored talks

followed in 2007 and 2008, with informal meetings in later years. The talks did not bridge the disagreement over the basis of negotiations, and no final agreement resulted.

● Confidence-Building Measures and Humanitarian Efforts

● The UN and UNHCR have supported confidence-building measures intended to

maintain family links between Sahrawi refugees in the Tindouf camps and their communities in Western Sahara. These measures included visits and communications between separated families. Implementation has faced difficulties, and the programme has remained on hold in recent years.

● Humanitarian agencies have continued to provide assistance in the refugee camps,

including food, health care, education and nutrition support. These efforts address urgent needs but cannot resolve the underlying political dispute or the long-term uncertainty faced by refugees.

● Security Council Resolutions and the Current Mandate

● The Security Council has repeatedly renewed MINURSO's mandate and called for a

just, lasting and mutually acceptable political solution providing for self-determination.

Resolution 2797 (2025) renewed the Mission until 31 October 2026 and called for

negotiations based on Morocco's autonomy proposal, while retaining self-determination as the stated objective. It did not settle the territory's final status or resolve the parties' fundamental disagreement.

5. Possible Approaches to a Political Settlement

● Autonomy Under Moroccan Sovereignty

● Morocco's 2007 autonomy proposal would establish self-government for Western

Sahara within Morocco. Regional institutions would manage certain internal affairs, while Morocco would retain sovereignty and control over areas such as defence and foreign affairs. Morocco considers this a basis for a lasting political settlement, while the Polisario Front maintains that independence must remain an option.

● A Referendum on Self-Determination

● The original UN settlement plan proposed a referendum through which eligible

Sahrawi voters could determine the territory's future. However, disagreements over

voter eligibility and the implementation of the process prevented the vote from taking place. Reviving this approach would require agreement on the electorate, the available choices and how the result would be implemented.

● A Negotiated Political Agreement

● UN-sponsored negotiations have sought a settlement acceptable to the parties.

Earlier proposals, including the 2003 Baker Plan, attempted to combine transitional autonomy with a later referendum on the territory's final status. These efforts did not succeed, as the parties disagreed over the proposed arrangements and their implications for sovereignty.

● Renewed Ceasefire and Security Cooperation

● Restoring a ceasefire could reduce hostilities and improve conditions for diplomatic

negotiations. MINURSO's monitoring role and mine-action activities remain relevant

to reducing security risks. However, a ceasefire would address the immediate conflict rather than determine Western Sahara's final political status.

● Humanitarian and Confidence-Building Measures

● Humanitarian assistance, family visits and other confidence-building initiatives can

help address the consequences of prolonged displacement and separation. Continued support for Sahrawi refugees near Tindouf is particularly important, although these measures would not independently resolve the underlying territorial dispute.

6. Other Relevant Information

6.1. The Legal Framework of Self-Determination

The principle of self-determination is central to the Western Sahara dispute. Under

international law, peoples have the right to determine their political status and pursue their economic, social, and cultural development. The United Nations has consistently treated Western Sahara as a Non-Self-Governing Territory whose final status remains unresolved. The dispute centres partly on how this principle should be implemented. The Polisario Front maintains that the Sahrawi people must be able to choose between independence and other political arrangements through a genuine act of self-determination. Morocco, meanwhile, argues that autonomy under Moroccan sovereignty offers a viable political solution. These competing interpretations have complicated efforts to establish a mutually accepted settlement.

6.2. The Role and Limitations of MINURSO

The United Nations Mission for the Referendum in Western Sahara (MINURSO) was

established in 1991 as part of the settlement plan intended to facilitate a referendum on the territory’s future. Its responsibilities have included monitoring the ceasefire, supporting related military arrangements, and assisting the United Nations’ efforts to address the dispute.

However, the referendum has never taken place, largely because of disagreements over

voter eligibility, the options to be presented, and the political conditions under which the process would occur. MINURSO’s continued presence has helped maintain an international role in the territory, but its limited mandate and the absence of a final political agreement have restricted its ability to resolve the underlying dispute.

In October 2025, the United Nations Security Council adopted Resolution 2797, extending

MINURSO’s mandate until 31 October 2026 and requesting a strategic review of the mission. This reflects continuing international involvement while highlighting the need to assess how the mission can contribute to progress towards a political settlement.

6.3. The Humanitarian Situation in the Sahrawi Refugee Camps

The unresolved status of Western Sahara has resulted in prolonged displacement among the Sahrawi population. Many Sahrawi refugees live in camps near Tindouf, Algeria, where

humanitarian assistance remains essential for access to food, clean water, healthcare, education, and other basic services.

Humanitarian organisations have reported continuing challenges associated with food

insecurity, limited economic opportunities, difficult environmental conditions, and dependence on external assistance. The isolation of the camps and the duration of displacement have also affected younger generations who have grown up without experiencing a resolution to the conflict.

The humanitarian situation is closely connected to the wider political dispute. While

emergency assistance addresses immediate needs, long-term improvements in living conditions remain linked to regional stability, sustained international support, and progress towards a durable political settlement.

6.4. Natural Resources and Economic Interests

Western Sahara possesses natural resources, including phosphates, fisheries, and

potentially significant renewable energy resources. These resources contribute to the territory's economic importance and have become a source of disagreement over sovereignty, consent, and the rights of the Sahrawi population.

Morocco administers much of the territory and has developed economic activities involving

its natural resources. However, the legal status of these activities has attracted international scrutiny, particularly concerning whether the Sahrawi people's interests and rights are adequately represented and whether they benefit from resource exploitation.

The issue extends beyond economic development. It raises questions about the relationship

between natural resource management, international law, and the political status of a

Non-Self-Governing Territory. Disagreements over resource exploitation have therefore

become another dimension of the broader conflict.

6.5. Regional Security and Morocco–Algeria Relations

The Western Sahara dispute has contributed to longstanding tensions between Morocco and

Algeria. Morocco supports autonomy under its sovereignty, while Algeria supports the

Sahrawi people's right to self-determination and hosts Sahrawi refugee camps. Their

opposing positions have affected diplomatic relations and hindered broader regional cooperation. These tensions have implications for security and economic integration across North Africa.

Limited cooperation between the two countries has complicated efforts to strengthen

regional institutions, coordinate responses to cross-border security threats, and develop closer economic ties. Mauritania also has an interest in the dispute because of its geographical position and its historical involvement in the conflict. Maintaining stability along regional borders and avoiding renewed escalation remain important considerations for neighbouring states.

6.6. The Sahrawi Arab Democratic Republic and International Recognition

The Sahrawi Arab Democratic Republic (SADR) was proclaimed by the Polisario Front in

1976. It is a member of the African Union, reflecting the support it has received from several

African states for Sahrawi self-determination. Morocco rejoined the African Union in 2017, despite its continued opposition to the SADR's status.

International recognition of the SADR remains divided. Some states recognise it as a

sovereign state, while others support Morocco's territorial claim or favour negotiations without formally recognising Sahrawi independence. Positions have also changed over time as governments have reassessed their diplomatic relationships and approaches to the dispute. This division has contributed to the conflict's international complexity. Although the African

Union provides a regional framework in which the issue is addressed, differing positions

among international actors continue to complicate the pursuit of a settlement accepted by all parties.

6.7. Prospects for a Lasting Settlement

The Western Sahara dispute remains unresolved because of fundamental disagreements

over sovereignty, self-determination, the future political status of the territory, and the conditions required for a legitimate settlement. These disagreements are reinforced by regional rivalries, differing international positions, humanitarian concerns, and competing economic interests. Previous United Nations initiatives have sought to establish a framework for negotiations and a mutually acceptable political solution. However, differences over the referendum process, autonomy proposals, and the meaning of self-determination have prevented the parties from reaching a final agreement.

A lasting settlement would depend on addressing these political and legal disagreements

while accounting for regional stability, humanitarian needs, and the interests of the Sahrawi population. The continued involvement of the United Nations and regional organisations remains an important part of international efforts to resolve the dispute.

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Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

“Research paper-I”

INDIAN SCHOOL DAR-ES-SALAAM MODEL UNITED NATIONS ECOSOC RESEARCH PAPER — TOPIC 1
Addressing Global Youth Unemployment and Skills Inequality Amidst Rapid Automation and the Transformation of the Global Labour Market

Council: Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

Issue: Global youth unemployment, skills inequality and automation

Introduction of the Topic:

The global labour market is undergoing a major transformation. Artificial intelligence (AI), robotics, algorithmic systems, digital platforms, and other automated technologies are changing how goods and services are produced, distributed, and consumed. These tools can raise productivity, improve safety, create industries, and make services more accessible. They can also change the tasks workers perform, reduce demand for some occupations, and increase the importance of skills that are not equally available to all young people. Youth unemployment predates the current wave of AI, but rapid technological change makes it more urgent. Young people often enter the labour market with limited professional experience, small networks, and little financial security. If employers increasingly require digital competence or experience with new technologies, young jobseekers without access to training may be excluded from emerging opportunities. Automation of entry-level tasks may also remove some of the first steps through which young people traditionally gain experience. The International Labour Organization (ILO) reported that 64.9 million young people aged 15–24 were unemployed worldwide in 2023, equivalent to a global youth unemployment rate of 13 percent. Around one in five young people were not in employment, education, or training (NEET). The ILO's 2026 edition of Global Employment Trends for Youth continues to examine the barriers young people face in obtaining decent work and highlights human-centred AI governance, lifelong learning, modern employment services, and broader social protection. The World Economic Forum's Future of Jobs Report 2025 projected that wider labour-market trends could create 170 million jobs and displace 92 million jobs by 2030, resulting in a projected net increase of 78 million jobs. These are projections, not guaranteed outcomes. New jobs may emerge in different locations and require different qualifications from those associated with displaced jobs. Skills inequality is central to this agenda. A young person with reliable internet, an appropriate device, quality education, and career guidance may be able to benefit from new forms of work. Another young person, even with equal ability and motivation, may be held back by poverty, limited infrastructure, disability barriers, discrimination, or a lack of training. ECOSOC must consider how international cooperation can help ensure that technological change supports inclusive development and decent work.

Definition of Key Terms:

Youth unemployment: Young people available for work and actively seeking employment who cannot find a job. International comparisons commonly define youth as ages 15–24, although national definitions vary. NEET: Young people who are not employed and are not participating in education or training. This indicator captures forms of exclusion that the unemployment rate alone may not show. Skills inequality: Unequal access to the knowledge, practical abilities, qualifications, and training needed to enter, retain, or progress in employment. Automation: The use of machinery, software, robotics, or digital systems to perform tasks previously completed by people or to assist people in completing them. Artificial intelligence (AI): Computer systems designed to perform tasks such as recognising patterns, generating content, analysing information, making predictions, or supporting decisions. Generative AI: A type of AI that produces content such as text, images, audio, or code in response to instructions. Digital divide: The gap between people with meaningful access to technology, connectivity, affordable devices, and digital skills and those without such access. TVET:

Technical and vocational education and training that develops practical and occupational skills relevant to particular industries or professions. Reskilling and upskilling: Reskilling means learning skills for a different role; upskilling means improving or expanding skills for a current or related role. Decent work: Work that provides fair income, safety, rights, social protection, and opportunities for personal development and social inclusion. Informal employment: Work not adequately covered by formal arrangements, labour protections, or social security systems. Skills mismatch: A situation in which a worker's skills or qualifications do not align with the tasks and requirements of the job they hold or seek. Labour-market transition: Movement between education, unemployment, jobs, occupations, or forms of employment. Active labour-market policies: Measures such as training, job-search assistance, career counselling, wage subsidies, and employment services intended to help people enter or return to work.

Background of the Issue:

1. The persistent challenge of youth employment

Young people face structural barriers when moving from education into work. Entry-level vacancies may be limited, employers may demand experience new graduates cannot yet have, and education may not provide the practical experience employers seek. In some countries, the number of young people entering the labour force grows faster than the number of secure jobs. Some young people experience prolonged unemployment, accept work below their qualification level, or rely on informal work with unpredictable income. The ILO's 2024 analysis found that the global youth unemployment rate had fallen to a 15-year low in 2023, but the recovery was uneven. A falling unemployment rate does not mean that every young person can find decent work. NEET rates, job security, wages, gender differences, and access to social protection reveal other dimensions of the problem. In some lower-income countries, young people work out of necessity without stable or adequately protected employment.

2. The changing nature of work

Technological progress has always changed the labour market. Mechanisation transformed agriculture and manufacturing; computers changed administration and finance; and the internet created new industries. AI and robotics may accelerate these changes by performing or assisting with a broader range of tasks, including tasks involving information, language, prediction, and routine decisions. It is important to distinguish between automating a task and eliminating an entire job. Most occupations contain multiple tasks. Technology may replace some tasks while increasing the value of others. Software might automate data entry while leaving human workers responsible for judgement, client relationships, complex problem-solving, and accountability. The outcome depends on the occupation, cost, regulation, infrastructure, and decisions made by employers and governments.

3. Why young workers may be especially exposed

Young workers are often concentrated in entry-level, temporary, customer-facing, administrative, retail, hospitality, and other roles containing tasks that digital systems may change. They may have less seniority and fewer opportunities to negotiate retraining or redeployment. If firms automate entry-level tasks, young people may lose not only jobs but also a first step through which they gain experience and progress into higher-skilled roles.

Background of the Issue (continued):

4. Skills inequality and the digital divide

Skills inequality is not simply a difference in individual effort. It reflects unequal resources for learning and practice. Reliable electricity, internet access, devices, qualified teachers, safe learning environments, language support, and accessible software all influence whether a young person can develop digital skills. Course and certification costs may prevent participation, particularly when young people need to earn income or support their families. Digital access alone is insufficient. A young person may own a smartphone but lack a computer suitable for technical training, affordable data, or a quiet place to study. Digital literacy also includes assessing information, protecting personal data, identifying misinformation, using software responsibly, and understanding AI's limitations. Programmes that distribute devices without instruction and ongoing support may have limited impact.

5. Gender, disability, location, and income

Barriers to work and training are not experienced equally. The ILO reported that two-thirds of young people who were NEET globally in 2023 were women. Care responsibilities, unequal access to education, unsafe transport, discrimination, and occupational segregation can restrict young women's opportunities. People with disabilities may face inaccessible platforms, training facilities, recruitment systems, and workplaces. Rural communities may have fewer training institutions and fewer technology-intensive employers than major cities. Low-income households may be unable to support unpaid internships or long periods of study. Disadvantaged young people may also lack professional networks and career guidance. If access to AI tools and advanced training is concentrated among privileged groups, automation may widen opportunity gaps. Inclusive policy should remove practical barriers rather than simply announce that training is available.

6. Demographic change and regional differences

Countries face different demographic and economic pressures. Some economies have ageing populations and labour shortages, while others have large youth populations that need substantial numbers of new jobs. The ILO has highlighted the expected growth of Africa's youth labour force through 2050. Without investment in education and productive sectors, unemployment and underemployment may remain high; with effective policies, young people can contribute to entrepreneurship, innovation, agriculture, industry, services, and sustainable development. Policies should be adapted to local conditions. A programme designed for a high-income country with broad broadband access may not work in a rural area with unreliable electricity. Not every young person needs advanced coding skills. Digital competence should be combined with skills relevant to local opportunities, including modern agriculture, healthcare, construction, logistics, tourism, renewable energy, and small-business management.

Background of the Issue (continued):

7. Education-to-employment mismatch

Many employers report difficulty finding applicants with the skills they need, while young people with qualifications struggle to find suitable work. This can result from a mismatch between fields of study and available jobs, limited practical training, uneven job creation, geographic barriers, and recruitment systems that place excessive weight on formal qualifications. In some developing economies, graduates compete for a limited supply of high-skilled positions. Education systems cannot predict every future occupation. A resilient approach combines foundational literacy and numeracy, digital competence, technical knowledge, and transferable skills. Communication, teamwork, creativity, critical thinking, adaptability, and ethical judgement remain valuable because workplaces need people who can interpret information, collaborate, and take responsibility.

8. Job quality and informal work

The objective should not be to move young people into any job at any cost. Employment can be insecure, poorly paid, unsafe, or lack social protection. Informal work is an important source of income in many economies, but can leave workers vulnerable to income shocks and exploitation. Digital platforms create flexible ways to earn money, yet platform workers may face uncertain earnings, limited bargaining power, and unclear access to benefits. Policies focused only on the number of jobs may overlook whether those jobs offer decent conditions. Training initiatives should be evaluated by placement, retention, earnings, working conditions, and whether participants obtain work related to their training—not only by enrolment or graduation numbers.

9. The role of employers and governments

Employers influence which tasks are automated, whether workers are consulted, and whether staff receive training. Governments shape education funding, labour laws, social protection, digital infrastructure, and incentives for investment. Worker organisations and youth groups can provide feedback on policy and workplace change. Because technology and supply chains cross borders, ECOSOC can help countries share evidence and coordinate approaches while respecting national priorities and the mandates of specialised agencies.

Understanding and Measuring the Evidence:

Delegates should use labour-market statistics carefully. The youth unemployment rate generally measures unemployed young people as a share of the youth labour force, not as a share of all young people. It counts people without work who are available for work and actively seeking it. Young people who have stopped looking may not be counted as unemployed, even if they would like a job. The NEET rate measures the share of young people who are neither employed nor participating in education or training. It includes unemployed young people and some people outside the labour force. NEET status does not describe one uniform experience: some people may be caring for relatives, some may be discouraged jobseekers, and others may face barriers related to disability, health, or local opportunity. Skills inequality is harder to measure. Possible indicators include access to broadband and devices, participation in TVET, digital-literacy levels, training completion, career guidance, and employment outcomes after training. These indicators should be disaggregated where data allow, including by sex, age, disability, income, location, and education level. Technology exposure is not the same as job loss. A task may be technically automatable without a business choosing to automate it. Adoption depends on cost, reliability, regulation, infrastructure, customer preferences, and the availability of workers who can use the technology. Estimates of future job creation and displacement should be presented as projections, not certainties. Questions for interpreting statistics What is measured? Unemployment, NEET status, underemployment, informal work, skills mismatch, and job quality are different outcomes. Which population is included? Check the age range, country coverage, year, and whether the figure refers to all young people or only the labour force. Is the figure observed or projected? Historical statistics describe measured outcomes; forecasts depend on assumptions. Who may be missing? Informal workers, rural communities, people with disabilities, and people outside formal education may be undercounted. Does training lead to decent work? Compare enrolment with placement, retention, earnings, and working-condition outcomes.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue:

The international community has developed frameworks, institutions, and programmes relevant to youth employment, skills development, decent work, and technological change. These provide a foundation for further action, although implementation and outcomes vary by country.

1. Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

The 2030 Agenda places employment and skills within a wider programme of inclusive growth. SDG 8 calls for sustained, inclusive and sustainable economic growth, productive employment, and decent work for all. Target 8.6 addressed reducing the proportion of young people not in employment, education, or training. SDG 4 focuses on inclusive quality education and lifelong learning, SDG 5 addresses gender equality, and SDG 9 includes infrastructure and innovation. These goals are interconnected. Quality education is less effective as an employment strategy if the economy does not create productive jobs. Economic growth may not reduce inequality if women and disadvantaged groups cannot access new opportunities. Digital infrastructure can support learning and business creation, but it needs to be affordable and accessible.

2. International Labour Organization (ILO)

The ILO conducts labour-market research, develops international labour standards, and works with governments, employers, and workers. Its Global Employment Trends for Youth 2024 examined youth unemployment, NEET rates, job quality, gender gaps, educational mismatch, and regional differences. Its 2026 report, Global Employment Trends for Youth: Back to the Future, highlights human-centred AI governance, technical and social capabilities, lifelong learning, modern employment services, social protection, and international cooperation. ILO work is relevant because youth employment is not only a question of economic growth; it is also a question of rights and job quality. International labour standards and social dialogue can help ensure that technology adoption does not undermine safety, fair treatment, and workers' ability to raise concerns.

3. UNESCO and skills development

UNESCO supports education systems and TVET. TVET can give young people practical skills linked to occupations and support transitions between education and work. Effective programmes require updated equipment, qualified instructors, links with employers, recognised qualifications, and access for disadvantaged learners. Training should also help learners continue developing skills as technology changes.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue (continued):

4. National employment and digital-skills programmes

Governments have established youth employment services, vocational institutions, coding programmes, digital-literacy courses, entrepreneurship schemes, public employment services, and hiring incentives. Some target rural youth, young women, people with disabilities, or workers in regions affected by industrial change. Effectiveness depends on whether courses respond to real demand, are accessible, and connect participants to employers or credible routes to self-employment. A recurring difficulty is that training may be offered without a clear pathway to work. Young people can complete courses but remain unemployed if employers are not hiring, qualifications are not recognised, or participants cannot afford transport and internet access. Strong programmes include career guidance, practical experience, employer involvement, and follow-up.

5. Apprenticeships and public-private partnerships

Partnerships among employers, governments, schools, universities, and training providers can align learning with workplace needs. Apprenticeships combine instruction with practical experience and help young people gain skills and references. Internships can provide exposure, but unpaid or poorly supervised placements may exclude low-income applicants and fail to deliver meaningful learning. Partnerships can support equipment, mentorship, curriculum development, and industry certification. Public oversight is important so training is not designed only around one company's short-term needs. Programmes should provide transferable skills that remain useful if participants change employer or sector.

6. Entrepreneurship and small-business support

Small businesses and self-employment can create opportunities where formal vacancies are limited. Youth entrepreneurship programmes may provide mentoring, financial-literacy training, business planning, market information, and access to appropriate finance. Digital tools can help small enterprises reach customers, but do not eliminate challenges such as unreliable infrastructure, limited purchasing power, competition, and access to capital. Entrepreneurship should be encouraged as one route among several, not as a universal solution. Not every young person has the resources or desire to establish a business, and poorly designed credit schemes can create debt without sustainable income.

7. Remaining gaps

Access remains uneven. Low-income countries may have limited fiscal space and digital infrastructure. Rural and marginalised communities may be distant from training centres. Some employers may not invest in retraining, and some

programmes do not publish enough outcome data to assess value for money. ECOSOC can help identify common priorities, share evidence, and encourage programmes that complement existing work.

Possible Solutions:

ECOSOC should consider recommendations that are practical, inclusive, measurable, and consistent with its coordinating role. No single policy can solve youth unemployment in every economy. A balanced strategy should combine education, job creation, worker protection, digital access, and support for groups facing barriers.

1. Expand affordable digital and vocational education

Member states should be encouraged to expand access to digital literacy, TVET, and training in fields relevant to national and regional labour markets. These may include AI literacy, cybersecurity, data analysis, digital marketing, renewable energy, healthcare, modern agriculture, logistics, construction, and other growing sectors. Training should be based on local evidence rather than the assumption that every young person needs the same specialisation. Programmes should combine technical skills with communication, critical thinking, teamwork, creativity, problem-solving, and ethical judgement. These transferable abilities can help young people adapt as software and occupations change. Qualifications should, where possible, be recognised and linked to demonstrable competencies.

2. Strengthen apprenticeships and work-based learning

ECOSOC can encourage partnerships among education providers, employers, and worker representatives to expand quality apprenticeships and paid internships. Employers can identify required skills and provide supervised work experience. Public support may help small businesses finance structured training, with safeguards to prevent exploitation or the replacement of regular paid jobs by low-cost trainees. Programmes should set clear learning objectives, ensure safe working conditions, provide mentoring, and publish completion and employment outcomes. Paid opportunities are especially important for young people who cannot afford to work without income.

3. Close the digital divide

Governments and international partners can support affordable broadband, reliable electricity, shared devices, community learning centres, accessible platforms, and offline learning resources. Investment should prioritise underserved areas and be paired with instruction. Schools, libraries, vocational centres, and community organisations can provide places to practise and receive support.

Possible Solutions (continued):

4. Build systems for reskilling and career transitions

Governments, employers, and training providers should identify occupations and tasks likely to change. Young jobseekers should have access to career guidance, modular courses, recognised certificates, job-matching services, and information about emerging sectors. Training can be delivered through vocational institutions, online platforms, community centres, or workplaces. Reskilling works best when connected to realistic opportunities. Providers should assess whether employers are hiring, whether participants can reach jobs, and whether skills will remain useful across workplaces. Employment services should help participants use their skills in applications and interviews and follow up after training.

5. Promote responsible, human-centred automation

Automation policy should recognise both productivity gains and risks to workers. Employers introducing major technological changes can be encouraged to assess likely impacts, consult workers, communicate plans, and explore retraining or redeployment before dismissals where feasible. Governments can promote responsible AI use, privacy, non-discrimination, transparency, and accountability in line with applicable laws and national contexts. The committee should avoid assuming that all automation destroys jobs or that new jobs will automatically compensate those who lose work. Outcomes depend on policy, investment, adoption speed, and the distribution of productivity gains. A human-centred approach aims to use technology to complement human capabilities and improve work where possible.

6. Improve social protection and job quality

Young workers in temporary, informal, freelance, or platform-based work may not have the same access to unemployment support, health protection, pensions, or paid leave as workers in standard employment. Member states can examine how social protection may be adapted to changing work patterns, taking national capacity and legal frameworks into account. Employment policies should support workplace safety, fair pay, protection against discrimination, and the ability to organise in accordance with national law and relevant international standards. Strong job-quality measures help ensure that employment growth improves young people's lives.

7. Encourage job creation in productive sectors

Skills programmes must be accompanied by demand for labour. Governments can support responsible investment in sectors with potential to employ young people, including sustainable agriculture, manufacturing, healthcare, education, tourism, digital services, infrastructure, and renewable energy. Promising sectors differ by country. Public investment should be assessed for cost, environmental impact, job quality, and long-term value.

Possible Solutions (continued):

8. Support youth entrepreneurship and small enterprises

Young entrepreneurs can benefit from mentoring, financial-literacy programmes, business incubators, access to markets, appropriate finance, and simpler administrative procedures. Digital platforms may help small businesses advertise products, receive payments, and reach customers. Support should not rely on credit alone: business advice, reliable infrastructure, market research, and consumer demand are also important. Programmes should pay attention to rural enterprises, young women entrepreneurs, social enterprises, and businesses that create decent jobs. Public support should be transparent and monitored. Institutions should share information about successful and unsuccessful approaches so future programmes improve.

9. Reduce gender and social inequalities

Training and employment initiatives should reach young women, people with disabilities, rural youth, low-income communities, and groups facing discrimination. Measures may include scholarships, accessible materials, safe transport, flexible schedules, mentoring, childcare support where appropriate, and anti-discrimination procedures. Recruitment platforms should be checked for barriers that unfairly exclude applicants. Data should be disaggregated where feasible. Equal enrolment does not necessarily mean equal outcomes: some groups may face greater difficulty completing courses, accessing internships, or obtaining paid work afterward. Programmes should address these differences directly.

10. Improve coordination and financing

ECOSOC can encourage coordination among member states, the ILO, UNESCO, other relevant UN entities, development banks, employers, workers' organisations, youth groups, and civil society. Existing initiatives should be mapped before new programmes are created. Partnerships should specify responsibilities, expected outputs, funding, reporting arrangements, and safeguards. Potential funding sources include national budgets, development assistance, voluntary contributions, eligible multilateral programmes, and private-sector investment. The appropriate mix depends on each country's circumstances. Funding proposals should estimate costs, identify beneficiaries, explain sustainability, and ensure that support reaches disadvantaged groups.

11. Measure outcomes and improve programmes

Monitoring should include more than the number of people trained. Useful measures include course completion, recognised qualifications, job placement, retention after six or twelve months, earnings, job quality, employer satisfaction, and access by gender, disability, income, and location. Data collection must respect privacy. Independent evaluation and participant feedback can reveal which programmes work and which need redesign.

Other Relevant Information:

1. The role and limits of ECOSOC

ECOSOC is one of the principal organs of the United Nations. It provides a central forum for discussion of international economic, social, and development issues and coordinates work across parts of the UN system. It can facilitate policy dialogue, encourage cooperation, consider research, and make recommendations. It does not function as a world legislature and cannot impose domestic employment laws on every member state. Draft resolutions should use realistic language such as 'encourages', 'invites', 'recommends', or 'calls upon' where appropriate. Delegates should distinguish between actions ECOSOC can take, actions it can recommend to states, and programmes requiring the participation or authority of other organisations.

2. Balancing innovation and worker protection

A productive debate should avoid two extremes: treating automation as inevitable catastrophe or assuming markets will automatically protect every affected worker. Technology can improve safety, reduce repetitive work, support healthcare and education, and enable new businesses. It can also increase surveillance, intensify work, create bias, or displace tasks without providing affected workers with a path to new employment. The relevant policy question is how technology is designed, adopted, governed, and shared. Consultation, training, transparency, fair recruitment, and social protection can manage risks while allowing innovation. The committee should consider both opportunities created by technology and costs borne by individuals and communities.

3. Avoiding one-size-fits-all policies

A country with a large formal manufacturing sector may need different measures from a country where many young people work in informal agriculture or services. Some countries need advanced technical training; others may first need foundational literacy, reliable electricity, or secondary education. A globally useful framework should establish shared goals while allowing countries to select policies suited to local conditions.

4. Responsible AI and digital safety

As young people use AI for learning and work, digital education should include privacy, cybersecurity, misinformation, copyright awareness, and critical assessment of generated information. AI systems may produce errors or reflect biases. Automated recommendations do not remove the need for human oversight and accountability.

5. Youth participation

Young people should participate in designing employment and training policies that affect them. Youth councils, student and worker organisations, consultations, surveys, and feedback channels can reveal practical barriers. Participation is meaningful when decision-makers explain how feedback influenced policy and when disadvantaged young people are represented.

Guiding Questions for Delegates and the Committee:

The following questions may help delegates research their national circumstances, develop proposals, and negotiate a balanced resolution. They guide discussion rather than prescribe one answer. How does automation affect youth employment in different sectors and regions, and how can delegates distinguish task transformation from total job displacement? What barriers prevent young people from accessing digital education, vocational training, and decent work in countries with different income levels? How can developing countries finance skills programmes and digital infrastructure without creating unsustainable public costs? What responsibilities should employers have when adopting technologies that significantly change tasks or the number of jobs? How can education combine technical competence with communication, creativity, critical thinking, teamwork, and ethical judgement? What measures would help young women, people with disabilities, rural youth, and low-income communities participate in emerging sectors? How can apprenticeships and internships provide genuine learning while avoiding exploitation or unpaid work that excludes poorer applicants? What roles can the ILO, UNESCO, development banks, private companies, and civil society play without duplicating existing programmes? How should ECOSOC encourage monitoring and reporting while respecting national circumstances and the mandates of relevant organisations? What indicators would demonstrate improved access to decent work rather than simply increased training enrolment? How can countries support young entrepreneurs without assuming that every young person can or should establish a business? What protections should be considered for young people in informal, temporary, freelance, or digital-platform employment? How can international cooperation support countries with limited internet access, electricity, training facilities, or qualified instructors? How should the benefits of higher productivity be distributed so technological progress supports workers, businesses, and society?

What a strong draft resolution should contain

Clear problem definition: Identify the groups and barriers the proposal addresses. Implementable actions: Name relevant actors, such as member states, the ILO, UNESCO, employers, or training providers. Funding and resources: Explain likely funding sources and how the proposal could be sustained. Inclusion: Address gender, disability, geography, affordability, and other barriers. Measurable outcomes: Include realistic indicators and reporting arrangements. Respect for mandates: Avoid giving ECOSOC powers it does not possess or assuming every country has identical resources.

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“Research paper-II”

ISDMUN II RESEARCH REPORT TOPIC 2

Committee: Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

Topic: Evaluating the Responsibility of Developed Nations to Finance Climate Adaptation and Resilience in Vulnerable Developing Countries Position: Chair Name: Hassan Harunani

Introduction

Climate change is now among the greatest threats to the international community. Climate change is endangering ecosystems, economies, public health, food security, and human settlements via rising temperatures, shifting rainfall, sea-level rise, and droughts and floods, as well as increasingly severe heatwaves. While such impacts are felt across the globe, countries' capacities to plan for and respond to these impacts vary greatly. Richer states tend to have more funding for climate change adaptation and mitigation, more technology, and more resilient infrastructure; and many developing countries may be at risk from climate change as well as being poor, having high public debts, less service provision, and other development problems. The question raised by this inequality for the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC): How much should be done by developed countries for adaptation and resilience in vulnerable developing countries and what is the way forward to achieve it? The issue is also strongly connected to climate justice as those countries who have emitted relatively small amounts of cumulative GHGs can suffer significant effects, having few resources to react to these effects. The international climate negotiation process has been increasingly acknowledging the need to consider historical emissions, economic capacity and economic vulnerability in climate action. The United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), the Kyoto Protocol and the Paris Agreement set the principles and mechanisms for international cooperation. But, what happens if the commitments are not followed by the necessary funding to the communities that need it? Issues about the amount of finance, using loans rather than grants, allocating funding and the efficacy of current mechanisms are still outstanding. This report explores the definitions of key terms, the evolution of 'climate finance', the current status of finance, the contributions of the major countries and institutions, and the barriers to implementation. The document ends with potential answers and recommendations for ECOSOC, whose mandate is on international economic cooperation and sustainable development, and which is a priority for climate resilience.

Definition of Key Terms

Climate Change Climate change is defined as long-term changes in weather patterns and temperatures. Global warming has occurred naturally in the past but there is now little doubt that human activities, particularly fossil fuel combustion, deforestation and industrial production, are the main drivers since the pre-industrial era. Carbon dioxide and methane are greenhouse gases that retain heat in the atmosphere and drive climate warming, and changes in rainfall and sea-levels. Developed Nations In general, developed countries are those with high average incomes, well established infrastructure, diversified economies and solid institutions. Many industrialized early, and built up considerable emissions that covered up the growth period of fossil fuels. International legal obligations rest on the agreement on which they are based and its categories, and are not necessarily tied to a country's economic development.

Developing Countries

Developing countries are countries that still have a tremendous amount of work to do in at least one of the following areas: economic, infrastructural, technological or social development. Highly vulnerable in activities related to the climate, including agriculture and fishing and tourism. They are not a uniform group: their emissions, resources, institutional capacities and climate risks differ widely.

Vulnerable Developing Countries

Vulnerable developing countries are those that are highly exposed to climate hazards and lack the capacity to anticipate, withstand and recover from the impacts of these hazards. There are several groups of countries that are often mentioned due to their specific vulnerabilities, such as the least developed countries, small island developing states, drought-prone countries and low-lying coastal states. Poverty and inequality, population exposure, governance, access to public services, are also key determinants of vulnerability.

Climate Adaptation

Climate adaptation is an adjustment of a human or natural system in response to actual or anticipated climate conditions that prevents or minimizes the damages or that takes advantage of potential benefits. This could include plans for flood protection, drought-tolerant crops, better water storage, etc., mangrove restoration, heat-health planning and early-warning systems.

Climate Resilience

Climate resilience is a community's capacity to anticipate, withstand, recover from and adapt to climate hazards. Adaptation actions can help build resilience, and resilience is the overall ability to respond to climate-induced disruption and remain resilient.

Climate Finance

Climate finance is financial resources that are utilized to address climate change. It can be delivered by the government, international institutions, development banks, private investors or other sources in a variety of forms, including grants, concessional loans, market rate loans, guarantees or equity. Climate finance can be used for adaptation, mitigation or responses to loss and damage, these are not the same.

Adaptation Finance Gap

The adaptation finance gap refers to the difference between the financing needed to fund adaptation needs, and the finance that is actually available. Can hinder country efforts to safeguard infrastructure, enhance water security, build health systems and adapt to climate change disasters.

Climate Justice

Climate justice is a concept which ensures that climate policies take into account fairness, historical responsibility, unequal vulnerability and capacities to respond. It acknowledges that the people who are most vulnerable to climate change may not be the ones that are most responsible. Common but Differentiated Responsibilities and Respective Capabilities (CBDR-RC) CBDR-RC is a basic rule of international environmental cooperation. It acknowledges that every state has a role to play in tackling climate change but that each state will have a different role to play, depending on their contribution to the problem and their ability to respond. The principle is of relevance in the sense that it provides an explanation for why it is believed that developed countries will be the first to provide climate finance. Loss and Damage Loss and damage refers to the climate impacts that are not preventable with mitigation and adaptation. This can encompass infrastructure damage, livelihood loss, loss of biodiversity, cultural loss and loss of ancestral land. Adaptation is aimed at minimizing risk while loss and damage arrangements are meant to cover those losses that remain.

Background Information

Early Climate Awareness and the UNFCCC The understanding of the human-caused climate change evolved during the twentieth century. Since 1988, the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) has enhanced the international review of the evidence, impacts and potential responses. The risks became more apparent and developing countries demanded that the financial burden of climate action was not the same for countries with different historical industrialization and capacities. In 1992, the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change was adopted and came into force in 1994. It laid the basic international principles for climate cooperation and acknowledged equity and common but differentiated responsibilities and respective capabilities. The Convention also set in place obligations and arrangements for financial support to assist developing countries in covering agreed costs of implementing the Convention. This was an important stepping stone for subsequent climate finance mechanisms. The Kyoto Protocol and the early funding mechanisms. The Kyoto Protocol was adopted in 1997 and came into force in 2005, with its first commitment period setting legally binding emissions reduction targets for countries that joined it that were developed. The Protocol was more on mitigation but did help build adaptation finance. The Adaptation Fund was set up to provide funding for concrete adaptation projects and programmes in developing countries parties to the Protocol. In 2001 the Marrakech Accords, a follow-up to the COP9 UNFCCC and Kyoto Protocol negotiations, were agreed, covering the financial aspects of the Protocol and adaptation financing. These developments shifted the focus of climate finance from abstract concepts to concrete institutions. Countries with fewer administrative capacities, however, still faced challenges due to limited resources, multiple application processes and project preparation technical requirements. The Copenhagen Commitment and the Green Climate Fund. Developed countries at the Copenhagen climate talks of 2009 agreed to aim for collective mobilisation of US$100 billion a year on climate action in developing countries by 2020. The target did not just focus on adaptation and extended to climate finance broadly. It was a yardstick to assess contributions, but it generated controversy as the deadline was not met and countries had varying views on how to count and what the value was of loans and private finance. The Green Climate Fund is an initiative created by the UNFCCC in response to decisions made at the UN Climate Change Conference in Cancún, Mexico in 2010. It was created to facilitate the mitigation and adaptation in developing countries, and to fund national climate priorities. It is now an integral component of the architecture of climate finance, but could be a challenge for countries lacking in institutional capacity to prepare proposals and implement safeguards when securing accreditation. The Paris Agreement of 2015. The Paris Agreement set the world's agenda to limit global warming, to enhance adaptation and to mobilize financial flows towards low-emission and climate-resilient development. Developed country parties shall continue to provide financial resources to developing country parties for mitigation and adaptation pursuant to this Convention, as set forth in Article 9. It also supports other partners to offer support on a voluntary basis. The Agreement acknowledges that support needs to build on existing support and consider the needs and priorities of developing countries, including especially vulnerable countries. However, it did not establish an amount of money to be contributed by individual developed countries. Scale, distribution,

accessibility and structure of finance have thus continued to be important negotiation issues. Glasgow and the New Climate Finance Goal. In 2021, developed countries were called on to at least double adaptation finance to developing countries from 2019 at COP26 in Glasgow. This was in response to the call for attention to adaptation to be given more priority than mitigation, even though communities have been undergoing significant climate impacts. According to the OECD in 2024, the developed world provided and mobilised total climate finance to developing countries of US$115.9bn in 2022, a first-time recorded surpassing of the pledge of US$100bn. This total was for adaptation and mitigation and different financial instruments; it was not an adaptation only figure. Countries have committed to a new target of investing US$300 billion annually by 2035, with developed countries leading the way, and scaling up finance from public and private sources to at least US$1.3 trillion annually by 2035 at COP29 in Baku in November 2024. While these agreements are significant steps, they do not guarantee a solution to the adaptation finance gap, but they are steps in that direction. The goal of the overall climate finance target is not just adaptation; and private investment is not always for projects or communities that yield very little direct commercial benefit.

Present Situation of Climate Adaptation Finance

The Adaptation Finance Gap

Under modelled cost estimates, developing countries would require around US$310 billion per year by 2035, and US$365 billion per year in extrapolated needs in countries' adaptation plans.Based on modelled cost estimates, developing countries would require about US$310 billion per year by 2035, and US$365 billion per year in extrapolated needs in countries' adaptation plans. The amount of international public adaptation finance provided to developing countries in 2023 was around US$26 billion. The figures represent a difference of approximately twelve to fourteen times the reported public flows, but were calculated by different methods and should be used accordingly. Adaptation requirements are climate resilient roads, flood protection, drought resistant agriculture, preparedness for public health, water systems, coastal protection, ecosystem restoration and disaster planning. Deferred investments can lead to greater future expenditures, particularly when preventive measures are delayed until after multiple disasters.

Adaptation and Mitigation

There has been a strong focus on mitigation, such as renewable energy and energy efficiency and emissions reduction, in climate finance. Limiting warming is key to lessening future risks and these investments are necessary. Mitigation, however, will not remove all climate effects that already are happening or are likely to happen over the next few decades. OECD data for 2022 showed that adaptation received about 28% of climate finance provided and mobilised by developed countries, and about 60% was for mitigation, with the remaining 10% going to cross-cutting activities. This distribution explains why overall climate finance figures are not enough to determine whether climate change adaptation needs are being addressed. Loans, Grants and Debt. Loans are required to be repaid, whereas grants are not required to be repaid. Loans can be helpful for projects that produce income, but may not be appropriate for critical public goods like flood-warning systems or coastal protection or public health planning. A US$100 million loan is not the same as a US$100 million grant since the recipient has to repay the principal and may have to pay interest on the loan. High debt servicing costs are already a reality in many developing countries. Grants and highly concessional instruments should be more widely applied in the adaptation finance context to meet the needs of countries with limited fiscal capacity, or in cases where projects are not directly generating financial returns. This should be determined by the country's debt situation and the type of project.

Access and Accountability

It takes time for countries to develop detailed proposals, carry out vulnerability assessments and prove their financial management capability and environmental and social safeguards before receiving funding approval. The procedures are designed to safeguard resources and may be less beneficial to governments that do not have the technical expertise. Access can be enhanced by simplified processes and readiness support, without taking away accountability. Contested reporting continues as well. However, there may be disagreement between donors and recipients on what is considered to be climate finance, the amount of private investment which can be attributed to public support, and whether loans are to be included at their face value or at their grant equivalent. It should be clear to report the difference between grants, concessional loans, market-rate loans, guarantees and private finance mobilised. Understanding the International Climate Funds. The Green Climate Fund is for adaptation and mitigation projects in developing countries. The Adaptation Fund provides funding for concrete adaptation projects and programmes, and the Global Environment Facility provides financing for environmental projects via the Least Developed Countries Fund and the Special Climate Change Fund. While these institutions are important in directing resources, effective replenishment, approval, distribution and reach to the most vulnerable communities are key to their effectiveness.

Major Countries and Organizations Involved

Developed Countries

Developed countries discussed in connection to developed country climate finance include the United States, European countries, Japan, Canada and Australia. They have considerable influence on the scale and design of global funding arrangements, for their industrial histories and their economic capacity and roles in international climate negotiations.

Their contributions, however, are not equal and the obligations and reporting categories that would be relevant differ depending on the international framework in question. Developed countries can claim climate finance has to be balanced with their own priorities, public budgets and the need to mobilise private investment. These are practical considerations but they do not take away the obligations under the UNFCCC and the Paris Agreement. Reliable multi-year contributions and clear reporting can help to balance national budget processes with international expectations.

Least Developed Countries and Small Island Developing States

Limited fiscal resources and technical capacity, as well as limited infrastructure are usually a problem for least developed countries (LDCs). Small island developing states (SIDS) are vulnerable to sea-level rise, coastal erosion, saltwater intrusion and tropical cyclones, and are typically characterized by high infrastructure costs and a small economic base. Groups of high vulnerability are often discussed in international climate policies because of the possibility that such groups might also lack the capacity to raise domestic finance. Programme funding should hence be based not just on population size or on the ability to prepare complex applications but also on the exposure to climate change and adaptation needs, institutional constraints and debt sustainability. The United Nations and the International Financial Institutions. The UNFCCC is the primary international climate venue for negotiations. UNEP evaluates the climate change adaptation finance gap and the IPCC evaluates the scientific evidence on climate change and impacts. OECD monitors climate finance given and mobilised by developed countries. Financial support is available through the Green Climate Fund, Adaptation Fund and Global Environment Facility. Multilateral development banks have the potential to finance and guarantee resilient infrastructure, and to assist with mobilisation of investment. But their decisions must consider debt sustainability and the reality of the fact that many of the adaptation projects yield public benefits and have no immediate commercial return. Developing-Country Governments and Local Communities The responsibilities of recipient government include determining national priorities, coordinating agencies, keeping up infrastructure, and ensuring that funding flows to the intended beneficiaries. Reducing misuse through transparent procurement, independent audits and effective monitoring. Local knowledge and insights from civil society organizations and communities are also a crucial source of information on environmental change, livelihood needs, and possible adaptation actions. They can have a positive impact on project design and accountability.

Private Sector

Investments in resilient infrastructure, agricultural technology, water management, insurance and climate information services. However, private investors might prefer projects that yield more predictable returns and shun socially valuable projects that fall short of profitable returns. It is therefore essential that private finance complements public grants and concessional support for essential adaptation measures, rather than replacing it.

Examples of Climate Vulnerability and Adaptation Needs

Agriculture, Water and Disaster Preparedness (Tanzania) The case of Tanzania is an important case of adaptation challenges in East Africa. Agriculture is an important livelihood and food security activity and fluctuations in rainfall and more frequent periods of drought, flooding, and increased temperatures may impact crops, livestock, water supplies, and the incomes of rural communities. Adaptation priorities are drought-tolerant crops, irrigation, water storage, watershed protection, forecasting and providing farmers with information on floods and climate. Adaptation finance from abroad is one way to finance more resilient Tanzania with less risk to resources for education, health, and development. The funding should be consistent with the national plans and local needs, and should involve technical expertise and maintenance, not just construction. Floods and Cyclones in Bangladesh Bangladesh is vulnerable to river floods, tropical cyclones, storm surges and sea-level rise. Cyclone shelters, early-warning systems, flood management, raised infrastructure, improved drainage and climate-resilient agriculture are some of the adaptation measures. It illustrates the need for physical infrastructure and for good disaster planning, community involvement and long-term upkeep when adapting.

The case of Small Island Developing States: Sea-Level Rise

Sea level rise, coastal erosion, saltwater intrusion, and damage to marine ecosystems pose a threat to countries like Tuvalu and Kiribati. These can affect housing, fresh water supplies, food production, tourism and cultural heritage. Some risks can be mitigated through mangrove restoration, coastal protection, freshwater management, and resilient infrastructure, but some impacts may be too great to adapt to. The examples demonstrate that adaptation finance does not have a one-size-fits-all approach. Should be able to address local risk factors, economic frameworks, institutional capability and community concerns. It should also provide the support not only for visible Infrastructure but also for planning, climate data, training and maintenance.

Ethical, Economic and Political Considerations

Historical Responsibility and Climate Justice

Many developed countries grew slowly and steadily using fossil fuels to drive their economies. These countries added a lot of greenhouse gases to the air. In contrast many developing countries added fewer gases but still suffer heavy climate damage and they have fewer tools to cope. The historical responsibility idea says that those who added more should pay money to fix the problem. Historical responsibility does not put the blame on every person in the world today. Historical

responsibility focuses on governments their gains and how rich they still are. A just sharing plan must also look at how much a country earns how many gases it releases today and how vulnerable the people who need help are.

Legal Responsibility

The UNFCCC and Article 9 of the Paris Agreement give a legal base for rich countries to give money.. The exact legal impact when a country does not give enough money depends on how the agreement is written, later choices and the laws that apply. The Paris Agreement does not set a fixed dollar amount that every rich country must give.

Economic and Strategic Responsibility

Storms and heat can break ports, roads, power lines and farms. This hurts trade and the chain of making goods. Putting money into systems can cut future damage keep economies steady and build better teamwork between nations. These common gains strengthen the argument for paying for adaptation. The help should go first to those who are most vulnerable and in need not just to projects that help the giver.

Domestic Governance and Accountability

Money can be lost if there is corruption, bad buying rules, weak watching or bad handling of projects. These worries should push for checks not for ignoring those who need help. Independent reviews, reports, clear buying rules and people taking part can help make sure the money does what it is meant to do. Rules for checking should fit the size of the country. Not be too hard, for small nations.

Other Past Efforts at Resolving the Problem

International efforts on climate finance have evolved over time. They started with principles and have moved toward specific financial goals, dedicated funding sources and formal reporting systems. The United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change or UNFCCC laid the groundwork by recognizing that developed countries should take responsibility and provide financial help to developing nations. The Kyoto Protocol and the Adaptation Fund built on this by offering project-based funding for climate actions. Then came the Copenhagen commitment, which set a target of $100 billion per year in climate finance from developed countries. The Green Climate Fund followed, expanding the system to support both mitigation and adaptation broadly. The Paris Agreement reinforced the importance of finance by including Article 9 which emphasizes support and links climate action to national needs, adaptation and resilience. Later the Glasgow Climate Pact called on developed countries to least double their adaptation finance compared to 2019 levels by 2025. At COP29 in 2024 countries reached an agreement: the New Collective Quantified Goal of at least $300 billion per year by 2035 led by developed countries. There was also a push to scale up overall climate finance to at least $1.3 trillion annually. These developments show that international cooperation on climate finance is progressing. Still there remains a gap between what is needed for adaptation and what is actually being delivered through public funding. The current mechanisms are not enough. Financial targets must be supported by tracking, fair sharing of resources easier access for developing countries and stronger focus, on the quality of finance—like whether support comes as grants or loans. Many challenges remain. The direction is clear: more and better-coordinated finance is needed to meet global climate goals.

Possible Solutions

Predictable and Transparent Contributions Developed countries should publish plans that span years and report both promised amounts and the money actually paid for climate finance. Reporting must separate grants, concessional loans, market-rate loans, guarantees and private finance that is mobilised. This approach would improve accountability. Make it easier to see whether financial goals are being met in practice.

Prioritising adaptation and Grant-Based Support

A larger portion of climate finance should go to adaptation projects in countries such as LDCs and SIDS. Grants should be prioritised for public goods and for countries that cannot take on more debt. Concessional loans can be used where projects bring returns but those loans must be checked against debt sustainability.

Simplifying Access to Climate Funds

Climate funds should make applications easier where it makes sense cut down approval times boost readiness support and give help to countries that have limited administrative capacity. Safeguards should still exist. Procedures must match the size and risk of each project.

Locally Led Adaptation

Local governments and affected communities should help set priorities, design projects and evaluate outcomes. Farmers, communities and indigenous groups often know the local environment and livelihoods best. Their participation can make programmes more relevant, build trust and ensure long-term sustainability. Technology Transfer and Capacity Building Money help should come with climate research, forecasting tools, technical training and affordable access to the technologies. Equipment alone is not enough: countries also need the know-how and institutions to run maintain and adjust systems over time.

Innovative and Complementary Finance

New sources can include finance, guarantees, well-designed international levies, debt-for-climate swaps, philanthropic donations and private investment in projects that make money. These mechanisms must be clear, fair. Add to reliable public contributions not replace them. Monitoring Outcomes Evaluation should look at more than how much money is promised. It must ask whether the money actually cuts vulnerability. Possible indicators are the share of finance that is disbursed how fast approvals happen the proportion of grants how funds are spread among countries, access, to early-warning systems, water security, agricultural resilience and community participation. A mix of environmental and social measures is needed to see the real impact.

Conclusion

The duty of countries to pay for climate change efforts in poor nations is a big topic in global climate talks. It shows how some countries have contributed more to climate problems in the past and have money to help. The UNFCCC and the Paris Agreement say rich countries should be the first to offer help but how much and what kind of help is still being talked about. Now the money given for adaptation is not enough. A 2025 study said poor countries will need between 310 and 365 billion dollars each year by 2035.. In 2023 only about 26 billion dollars was given. A new goal set at COP29 is a step but it covers all types of climate money and does not promise that adaptation will get enough support. Rich countries have reasons to help. They have a duty, political reasons and legal agreements to do so. They also have the money. Can benefit from less climate damage. At the time the countries that receive help and the groups that manage the money must make sure the funds are used clearly with people involved and work done properly. Future steps should focus on help money for basic needs easier access to funds sharing technology and checking if the help works. In the end money for climate change should not just be about the numbers talked about in meetings. It should be about whether it helps poor countries protect people build economies and get ready, for a changing world. Rich countries should keep helping over time while all countries work together to make the world more fair and strong.

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Human Rights Council

(HRC I)

“Research paper-I”

Council: Human Rights committee (H.R.C I)

Issue 1: Balancing the Right to Peaceful Assembly and Freedom of Expression with National Security Imperatives in an Increasingly Volatile Global Environment

President chair: Elinkunde Akyoo

Deputy chair: Krishiv Patel

Introduction of the Topic:

The tensions between safeguarding fundamental human freedom and preserving national security has emerged as one of the defining legal and political dilemmas of the twenty-first century. Article 19 and Article 20 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) adopted in1948, boldly protects the rights to freedom of opinion, expression, and peaceful assembly. However, our increasingly violent global environment is jam-packed with issues such as: geopolitical conflicts, political polarization, civil unrest, and emerging digital threats. Governments worldwide are escalating security measures to safeguard public order and national sovereignty. While the international law recognizes that certain rights may be restricted under strictly defined conditions,such as public safety or national defense, the abuse of "national security" as a cover to suppress legitimate dissent, peaceful protests, and journalistic freedom has reached alarming levels. States frequently deploy broad counter-terrorism laws, internet shutdowns, arbitrary arrests, using tear gas on protesters, and mass national surveillance technologies to silence opposition. State authorities counter argue that unrestricted gatherings and unchecked communication can be weaponized by violent extremist groups, foreign adversaries, or insurgent movements to destabilize democratic governance. The Human Rights Committee is therefore tasked with evaluating how international legal frameworks can be reinforced to ensure that legitimate security concerns do not erode the fundamental rights to expression and assembly amongst citizens. Despite the creation of legal frameworks and laws by the UN. The UN lack the the power to enforce these laws in sovereign Nations which poses limitations to these laws being followed through honestly and wholly throughout the world.

Definition of Key terms:

● Peaceful Assembly: The non-violent gathering of individuals in a public or private space for a

specific purpose, including demonstrations, strikes, processions, and rallies, protected under international human rights law.

● Freedom of Expression:The fundamental right of everyone to hold opinions without interference

and to seek, receive and impart information and ideas through any media and regardless of frontiers.

● Public safety: The welfare and protection of the general public, being a responsibility of the

government to ensure the security and well-being of its citizens.

● National defense:All measures a nation takes to protect itself from enemies, including

safeguarding its collective ideals and values encompassing the nation's military.

● National security:Measures and strategies developed by a nation to protect its citizens,

institutions, and interests from both internal and external threats such as: military aggression, terrorism, civil unrest, and even natural disasters.

● Espionage laws:Criminalize of spying, gathering or transmitting private military and national

defense data to foreign nations/enemies.

● Sedition laws:Criminalize advocating for, conspiring, or inciting the forceful and violent

overthrow of a government or its laws.

Background of the Issue:

Historically, rights to petition, assembly, and free speech emerged as mechanisms to limit monarchical or tyrannical power. However, even early sovereign states viewed public assemblies and uncensored speech with deep suspicion, treating large gatherings as potential precursors to riots, treason, or violent revolution. The modern framework of suppressing dissent as "national security" intensified during times of major international or civil conflict.During World Wars I and II, nations routinely passed espionage, sedition, and treason laws that criminalized anti-war protests, political criticism, and foreign-language publications. Emergency declarations during wartime established the legal precedent that the state could suspend fundamental rights whenever public order or territorial integrity was perceived to be at risk, thus making way for the vague and overbroad legislative laws that are written, suppressive laws that are misused by nations today to suppress civil rights.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue:

The international community has made countless to temps to set up standards, legal tests and oversight mechanisms to prevent countries from Miss using national security claims to suppress their public's rights to expression. An example of this is the Johannesburg principal established in 1995. Which was developed to dress the freedom of expression, its principles state that assemblies can only be restricted under national security grounds, if ,they can prove that the expression was intended to cause or inspire violence. Secondly in response to the rise in national international towns and extreme digital surveillance, the OHCHR has issued guidance condemning state sponsored network shutdowns and targeted spyware deployment against activists and journalists.

Possible Solutions:

Governments can use advanced digital tools such as facial recognition, or AI social media monitoring, to allow governments to identify the planning of protests, and track protest organizers before or during demonstrations in the case of any violent actions or damage to public property occurring. Journalist's news can also be cross checked in these ways as well to ensure that they are following the strict non-malicious guidelines for them and are posting accurate information with proof. Governments can also submit to the UN better specified documents highlighting the actions that they choose to take specified to their geographical area (eg: sub-saharan Africa and Eastern Europe), in order to ensure each country's laws are specified to the leadership, communities and social constructs that their communities follow. This will ensure that the UN can target specific countries are geographical locations in which have the tendency to twist general UN laws to serve their dictative governments instead

Other Relevant Information:

Concentrations of the restrictions of the rights to freedom of expression and peaceful gathering

geographically and their reasons why include:

MENA: Is an area with extensive restrictions on public gatherings and state surveillance. National security and anti-protest laws are widely used across the region to restrict opposition movements and unauthorized assemblies. Eastern Europe and Central Asia: Many countries in this region rely on severely strict NGO registration laws and frameworks to prevent public demonstrations, target political uproar and foreign funded organizations. Sub-Saharan Africa: National security arguments are frequently invoked during election cycles or periods of economic unrest. Authorities in various states periodically implement internet shutdowns, ban public rallies, or utilize military police units to harshly disperse public demonstrations. Western Democracies: even though constitutional protections exist, established democracies face scrutiny over the expansion of police powers, preemptive protest bans, and the heavy reliance on digital surveillance and anti-protest legislation targeting environmental and political movements.

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“Research paper-II”

Council: Human Rights Committee (H.R.C I)

Issue 2: Safeguarding Freedom of Expression in the Digital Age: Countering Disinformation Without Undermining Independent Journalism and Civil Liberties

President Chair: Elinkunde Akyoo

Deputy Chair: Krishiv Patel

Introduction of topic:

Over a period of years, tension and widespread anti-sentiment has rose over the rapid expansion of the internet and global connectivity. They’ve changed how people can access news, share and collaborate, as well as discuss with others abroad, making it a vital piece of news and communication. However, this rapid spread of information makes it easier for false and misleading claims to circulate around the globe, making it an international concern. These disinformation corresponds to influencing political situations, bruising reputations, and exacerbating social boundaries. These claims can cause confusion and pandemonium. As a result of these, governments introduced measures to address this, such as the censorship of the press and control over individual outlets. Article 19 however, states the protection of the freedom of speech and expression, including the right to publish and write claims freely. These independent outlets are key to exposing fraud or corruption and silencing them leads to a violation of the article. Due to this, the United Nations has recognized the requirement to address disinformation. Through safeguarding human rights, stating responses to misinformation and disinformation, as well as allowing for transparency.

Definition of key terms:

Freedom of expression is the right that humans have to express opinions, share thoughts and ideas and communicate with others without interference. Disinformation is the deliberate false / misleading information that can lead to crisis and confusion that deceives people and can influence their thoughts and actions. Misinformation is the false or inaccurate information shared / communicated without intending to mislead. Independent journalism is the practice of reporting and writing news and investigating issues without proper control or external influence.

Civil liberties are the basic freedoms and rights of individuals that protect them from unjust interference such as the freedom of expression or the press. Freedom of the press is the right for journalists and the media to report their own news and investigate it for the matters of public interest without interference. Human Rights Fundamental rights and freedoms that belong to every person, regardless of nationality, ethnicity, gender, religion, or other status.

Background information:

Governments and digital platforms have introduced different measures to address this problem, including fact-checking, content moderation, and laws against the spread of false information. However, these measures can create other concerns. Some governments have used disinformation laws to restrict criticism, silence journalists, or control what people can access online. Freedom of expression is protected under Article 19 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights. Independent journalism also plays an important role by investigating public issues, checking claims, and holding those in power accountable. For this reason, efforts to counter disinformation must not become an excuse for censorship or unjustified restrictions on civil liberties. The United Nations and organisations such as UNESCO have encouraged international cooperation, media literacy, and greater transparency from digital platforms. Despite these efforts, finding the right balance remains a challenge.

Attempts to solve the issue:

1. International Human Rights Law

● The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR), adopted in 1948, protects freedom of opinion and expression under Article 19.

● The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), adopted in 1966, also protects the right to seek, receive, and share information.

● These agreements establish that governments must respect freedom of expression, although certain restrictions are allowed under specific conditions.

● Limitation: Some governments introduce laws against false information that can also be used to silence journalists, activists, or political opponents.

● Link to the topic: Efforts to fight disinformation must follow international human rights standards.

2. UNESCO's Initiatives

● UNESCO has worked to address disinformation by promoting media literacy, fact-checking, and support for independent journalism.

● Its Internet for Trust initiative focuses on making digital platforms more transparent and accountable while protecting human rights.

● UNESCO also encourages people to develop the skills needed to identify false or misleading information.

● Limitation: These efforts depend on cooperation between governments, digital platforms, journalists, and the public.

● Link to the topic: Education and reliable journalism can help counter disinformation without relying mainly on censorship.

3. Council of Europe's Report on Information Disorder (2017)

● The Council of Europe published a report titled Information Disorder: Toward an Interdisciplinary Framework for Research and Policy Making.

● It examined how false and misleading information spreads online and how it affects society.

● The report proposed recommendations for governments, technology companies, media organisations, and civil society.

● It highlighted the importance of media literacy, fact-checking, and quality journalism.

● Limitation: The report provides recommendations rather than a single legally binding international solution.

● Link to the topic: Tackling disinformation requires cooperation between different groups, not just government restrictions.

4. European Union's Digital Services Act (DSA)

● The EU introduced the Digital Services Act in 2022, with its main obligations applying from 2024.

● It requires online platforms to be more transparent and accountable for certain risks connected to their services.

● Very large platforms and search engines must assess and address systemic risks, including those affecting fundamental rights and elections.

● The Act also includes transparency requirements for content moderation.

● Limitation: Strict moderation measures may lead to legitimate content being removed, raising concerns about freedom of expression.

● Link to the topic: The DSA provides an example of how platforms can be regulated while including protections for users' rights.

5. EU Code of Practice on Disinformation

● The EU introduced the Code of Practice on Disinformation in 2018 and strengthened it in 2022.

● It brings together digital platforms, fact-checkers, advertisers, and other organisations to address the spread of disinformation.

● Its measures include improving transparency, addressing the financial incentives behind disinformation, and supporting fact-checking.

● In 2025, the code was integrated into the framework of the Digital Services Act.

● Limitation: Commitments and enforcement can vary, so monitoring and accountability remain important.

● Link to the topic: Cooperation between platforms, governments, and independent organisations can help reduce disinformation.

6. UN Global Digital Compact (2024)

● The Global Digital Compact was adopted by UN Member States in September 2024 as part of the Pact for the Future.

● It provides a framework for international cooperation on digital technology, including information integrity, digital inclusion, and human rights online.

● It encourages countries to work together towards a safer and more inclusive digital environment.

● Limitation: It is a framework for cooperation rather than a single global law that automatically enforces its commitments in every country.

● Link to the topic: It gives the international community a foundation for developing shared approaches to disinformation while respecting human rights.

Possible responses:

There are several ways to counter disinformation while protecting freedom of expression. One approach is to introduce media literacy programmes in educational institutions. These programmes could teach students how to use online platforms responsibly, evaluate sources, and distinguish reliable information from false or misleading claims. UNESCO and other relevant organisations could provide resources and training to support these programmes.

Another approach is to introduce legislation requiring social media platforms to be more transparent about how they operate. This could include explaining their content moderation policies, how they identify misleading information, and how decisions to remove or restrict content are made. Users should also have the right to appeal decisions they believe are unfair. Furthermore, the protection of independent journalists could be strengthened through journalist safety programmes, training, and legal protections. This would help protect journalists from threats, harassment, and unjustified government or external interference while allowing them to report on matters of public interest. International cooperation between governments, social media platforms, independent media organisations, and civil society could also help address disinformation. These groups could cooperate with independent fact-checkers to provide evidence and context for misleading claims. However, safeguards should be established to prevent governments or other powerful groups from pressuring fact-checkers or platforms to suppress legitimate criticism. In addition, the United Nations and relevant organisations could support independent fact-checking organisations by providing resources, training, and access to reliable information. These organisations should be able to operate without political interference, allowing the public to access evidence-based information and make informed decisions. Governments could also be encouraged to release accurate and timely public information, particularly during elections, emergencies, and other important events. Making non-confidential information accessible to the public and available in different languages would help journalists verify claims and reduce the spread of disinformation. Finally, social media platforms and advertisers could introduce fair and transparent measures to reduce advertising revenue generated by accounts that repeatedly spread deliberate disinformation. These measures should be based on clear evidence and allow appeals to prevent political bias or the unfair restriction of legitimate expression.

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Human Rights Council

(HRC II)

“Research paper-I”

RESEARCH PAPER 1 Council: Human Rights Council (HRC)

Issue: Balancing the Right to Peaceful Assembly and Freedom of Expression with National Security Imperatives in an Increasingly Volatile Global Environment

Position: HRC Chair

Student Officer: Joan Mahamba

Introduction of the Topic:

The protection of human rights remains one of the fundamental responsibilities of the international community. Among these rights, freedom of expression and the right to peaceful assembly are essential to ensuring that individuals can communicate their opinions, challenge government policies, demand accountability, and participate in public affairs. These freedoms allow citizens to raise concerns regarding corruption, inequality, discrimination, economic hardship, and other issues affecting their communities. However, in an increasingly volatile global environment, the exercise of these rights has become closely connected to questions of national security and public order. States face a range of security challenges, including terrorism, armed conflicts, political instability, violent extremism, organised crime, and widespread civil unrest. Governments are responsible for protecting their populations and maintaining public safety. As a result, some states have introduced restrictions on public demonstrations, increased surveillance of political activities, limited access to certain communication platforms, or strengthened laws governing public gatherings. Although such measures may be introduced in response to genuine security concerns, they can also create risks when applied excessively or without sufficient legal safeguards. The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), particularly Articles 19 and 21, establishes international protections for freedom of expression and peaceful assembly. These provisions also recognise that certain restrictions may be permissible under specific conditions. However, restrictions must comply with the applicable requirements of legality, necessity, and proportionality and must serve a legitimate purpose recognised by the Covenant. Governments cannot automatically justify the suppression of peaceful demonstrations or political criticism by referring to national security. The increasing role of digital technology has further complicated this issue. Social media platforms enable demonstrations to be organised rapidly, allow journalists to document incidents in real time, and provide individuals with alternative sources of information. At the same time, digital platforms may facilitate the spread of inflammatory content, threats, and calls for violence. Authorities must therefore determine how to address genuine threats without restricting lawful communication or preventing citizens from exercising their fundamental freedoms. Consequently, the Human Rights Council must consider how states can preserve national security while ensuring that freedom of expression and peaceful assembly remain protected. The Committee should focus on developing practical solutions that promote public safety, accountability, respect for human rights, and constructive cooperation between governments and civil society.

Definition of Key Terms:

Freedom of Expression: The right to seek, receive, and impart information and ideas through any media, as protected under Article 19 of the ICCPR, subject to the Covenant's applicable restrictions.

Peaceful Assembly: The right of individuals to gather collectively for purposes such as demonstrations, protests, public meetings, and campaigns, provided the assembly falls within the protection of peaceful assembly under international human rights law.

National Security: The protection of a state's population, institutions, territorial integrity, and essential functions against genuine security threats, subject to international law and applicable human rights obligations.

Public Order: The conditions necessary for the functioning of society and the protection of public safety, rights, and freedoms. Public order must not be used as a vague justification for suppressing peaceful opposition.

Proportionality: The principle that restrictions on human rights must not exceed what is necessary to achieve a legitimate objective.

Necessity: The requirement that a restriction must respond to a legitimate and sufficiently substantiated need rather than being imposed merely because it is convenient for the authorities.

State of Emergency: A formally proclaimed situation in which a state faces an exceptional public emergency threatening the life of the nation. Any derogation from ICCPR obligations must satisfy Article 4 and its safeguards.

Civic Space: The environment in which individuals and organisations can exercise freedoms of expression, peaceful assembly, and association and participate in public affairs without unjustified interference.

Internet Shutdown: An intentional disruption or restriction of internet connectivity or digital communications, often affecting access to information and the ability to communicate or organise collectively.

Background of the Issue:

The international recognition of peaceful assembly and freedom of expression developed significantly following the Second World War. In 1948, the United Nations adopted the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR), whose Articles 19 and 20 recognise freedom of expression and the right to peaceful assembly and association. These provisions established important international principles concerning individual liberty and public participation. In 1966, the adoption of the ICCPR further strengthened these protections. Article 19 protects freedom of expression, while Article 21 safeguards peaceful assembly. Although the Covenant permits certain restrictions, governments must meet specific legal requirements before limiting these rights. This framework reflects the principle that public security and individual freedoms must be considered together rather than treating one as an automatic justification for disregarding the other. Throughout the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, demonstrations have played an important role in political and social change. Peaceful movements have been used to demand democratic reforms, labour protections, gender equality, racial justice, and government accountability. However, public demonstrations have also occurred during periods of political instability, armed conflict, and serious civil unrest, requiring authorities to manage public safety while respecting the rights of participants. The expansion of digital communications has created additional challenges. Protest organisers can now communicate rapidly through online platforms, while journalists and human rights defenders can document the conduct of security forces and disseminate information internationally. Governments may also use digital surveillance to identify individuals involved in demonstrations or restrict communications during periods of unrest. These developments have raised questions concerning privacy, freedom of expression, and the lawful limits of state monitoring. In 2020, the UN Human Rights Committee adopted General Comment No. 37 on Article 21 of the ICCPR. The document clarified that peaceful assembly is a fundamental right and that authorities should generally presume assemblies to be peaceful. It also emphasised that isolated acts of violence by certain participants do not automatically make an entire assembly non-peaceful. The present challenge is therefore to establish effective security policies without allowing legitimate concerns about violence or instability to become grounds for unnecessarily restricting public participation. The HRC must consider how international standards can be translated into practical national legislation, law enforcement procedures, and accountability mechanisms.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue:

The international community has undertaken several initiatives to strengthen the protection of peaceful assembly and freedom of expression while addressing security concerns. Among the most important developments is the adoption of the ICCPR, which provides a legal framework for determining when restrictions on freedom of expression and peaceful assembly may be justified. Article 19 establishes specific conditions for restricting expression, while Article 21 provides corresponding safeguards for peaceful assemblies. These provisions require governments to justify restrictions under the applicable standards rather than relying on unrestricted discretion. Another important development was the UN Human Rights Committee's General Comment No. 37 in 2020. This document clarified states' obligations concerning the facilitation and protection of peaceful assemblies. It addressed matters such as the use of force, restrictions on gatherings, surveillance, and the protection of individuals monitoring or reporting on demonstrations. The UN Human Rights Committee's General Comment No. 34, adopted in 2011, also strengthened the interpretation of Article 19 by addressing freedom of opinion and expression. It emphasised the importance of public debate, access to information, and the protection of expression concerning matters of public interest. Furthermore, the UN Human Rights Council has repeatedly addressed the protection of human rights in the context of public demonstrations and digital communications. The UN human rights system provides mechanisms for monitoring alleged violations, issuing recommendations, supporting national institutions, and encouraging states to align domestic legislation with international standards. Despite these efforts, implementation remains uneven. Some states continue to impose broad restrictions on demonstrations, while others face difficulties in providing adequate training for law enforcement officers or establishing effective

independent oversight. In certain situations, emergency regulations remain in force beyond the circumstances that originally justified them. The continuing challenge is therefore not simply the absence of international standards, but the need for consistent implementation, accountability, and cooperation.

Possible Solutions:

When addressing the relationship between public freedoms and national security, the Human

Rights Council can consider several measures to encourage a balanced and practical approach.

- Strengthening Human Rights-Compliant Legislation: The Committee should encourage states

to review laws governing demonstrations, public order, and national security. Such laws should clearly define permissible restrictions and prevent vague provisions from being used to suppress peaceful political expression.

- Promoting Proportionate Law Enforcement: States should provide specialised training for

security personnel in de-escalation, negotiation, crowd management, and the appropriate use of force. Law enforcement officers should distinguish peaceful participants from individuals committing specific unlawful acts.

- Establishing Independent Accountability Mechanisms: The Committee should encourage

independent investigations into allegations of excessive force, arbitrary detention, and unlawful restrictions. National human rights institutions, courts, and independent oversight bodies can help ensure that violations are addressed and victims have access to effective remedies.

- Protecting Journalists and Human Rights Defenders: Journalists, medical personnel, legal

observers, and human rights defenders should be able to monitor demonstrations without unjustified interference. States should establish safeguards against intimidation, arbitrary arrest, and the unlawful confiscation of equipment used to document events.

- Safeguarding Digital Rights: Governments should avoid unnecessarily broad internet

shutdowns and restrictions on digital communications. Any limitations must be assessed under applicable human rights obligations, while lawful and proportionate investigative measures may be used to address specific and credible threats.

- Introducing Safeguards for Emergency Powers: States should ensure that emergency

measures have a clear legal basis, remain limited to what is strictly required by the circumstances, and are subject to appropriate oversight and periodic review.

- Encouraging Dialogue Between Governments and Civil Society: Regular consultation between

authorities, community representatives, protest organisers, and civil society organisations can help resolve grievances, reduce misunderstandings, and prevent peaceful demonstrations from escalating into violence.

- Strengthening International Cooperation: The HRC should encourage technical assistance, the

sharing of good practices, and cooperation between national human rights institutions and relevant UN mechanisms. Such initiatives can help states strengthen institutional capacity while preserving national responsibility for implementation.

- Addressing the Root Causes of Civil Unrest: Governments should consider peaceful public

demonstrations as opportunities to identify unresolved grievances. Measures addressing corruption, inequality, discrimination, and limited access to public participation can help reduce tensions and strengthen confidence in public institutions.

- Improving Monitoring and Evaluation: States should develop transparent procedures for

reviewing protest-related restrictions, evaluating law enforcement conduct, and assessing the effectiveness of security policies against clear human rights standards.

Other Relevant Information:

The relationship between peaceful assembly and national security is influenced by differences in political systems, legal traditions, institutional capacity, and security conditions. States facing armed conflict or credible threats of terrorism may encounter different practical challenges from states experiencing peaceful demonstrations concerning economic or political reforms. Nevertheless, all states must comply with their applicable international obligations. Developing countries may face additional difficulties in financing law enforcement training, maintaining independent oversight institutions, and ensuring that all communities have access to legal remedies. International technical assistance can help address these challenges without imposing a single institutional model on every country. Digital technology is also changing the nature of public demonstrations. Online platforms allow participants to share information, document alleged abuses, and coordinate peaceful gatherings. However, they can also facilitate surveillance, targeted harassment, and the rapid circulation of misleading information. Any proposed response should therefore distinguish between legitimate digital participation and conduct that presents a demonstrable and legally relevant threat.

Another important consideration is the role of public trust. Security measures that are transparent, consistently applied, and subject to independent review may help strengthen confidence in state institutions. Conversely, arbitrary restrictions and excessive force may deepen grievances and increase tensions. The Human Rights Council should therefore recognise that national security and human rights protection are interconnected responsibilities. The Committee should seek solutions that allow states to address genuine threats while preserving peaceful participation, independent reporting, and the rule of law.

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“Research paper-II”

RESEARCH PAPER 2 Council: Human Rights Council (HRC)

Issue: Safeguarding Freedom of Expression in the Digital Age: Countering Disinformation Without Undermining Independent Journalism and Civil

Position: HRC Chair

Student Officer: Joan Mahamba

Introduction of the Topic:

The rapid development of digital technology has fundamentally transformed the way individuals communicate, access information, and participate in public affairs. Social media platforms, online news outlets, messaging applications, and artificial intelligence have created opportunities for individuals to share information across borders, express political opinions, and hold public institutions accountable. The digital environment has also expanded access to information for communities that have historically faced barriers to traditional media. However, these developments have introduced significant challenges concerning disinformation, online manipulation, independent journalism, and the protection of civil liberties. Disinformation has become a major concern for governments, international organisations, and civil society. False or misleading information deliberately circulated to deceive audiences can undermine public trust, influence electoral processes, intensify social divisions, and contribute to discrimination or violence. During elections, armed conflicts, public health emergencies, and periods of political instability, coordinated information campaigns may make it difficult for individuals to distinguish reliable reporting from fabricated claims. In response, governments and digital platforms have introduced content moderation policies, fact-checking programmes, online safety legislation, and other measures intended to address the spread of harmful information. Nevertheless, these measures can create additional human rights concerns when their definitions are excessively broad or their enforcement lacks transparency. Laws designed to counter disinformation may be used to silence political opposition, restrict independent reporting, or penalise individuals who criticise public authorities. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR), particularly Article 19, recognises the right to freedom of opinion and expression, including the freedom to seek, receive, and impart information and ideas through any media and regardless of frontiers. Article 19 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR) further protects these freedoms while permitting certain restrictions under specified legal conditions. The United Nations Global Principles for Information Integrity, launched in June 2024, provide an additional framework for addressing information-related challenges. They emphasise public empowerment, transparency, independent and pluralistic media, societal resilience, and responsible incentives within the digital information environment. Consequently, the Human Rights Council must consider how the international community can address deliberate information manipulation without granting governments or private companies excessive control over public discourse. The Committee should focus on solutions that strengthen reliable information, protect independent journalism, promote digital literacy, and preserve the fundamental freedoms necessary for an open and accountable society.

Definition of Key Terms:

Freedom of Expression: The right to seek, receive, and impart information and ideas through any media, protected under Article 19 of the ICCPR, subject to applicable international human rights restrictions.

Disinformation: False or misleading information deliberately created, presented, or disseminated to deceive or manipulate an audience.

Misinformation: False or inaccurate information shared without necessarily intending to deceive. It may arise from misunderstandings, outdated information, or the unintentional circulation of incorrect claims.

Malinformation: Genuine information used or presented in a harmful or misleading manner, such as the disclosure of private information to intimidate an individual. The term must be applied carefully so that legitimate investigative journalism is not incorrectly classified as harmful conduct.

Independent Journalism: Journalism conducted with editorial independence from inappropriate political, commercial, or other interference, allowing reporters to investigate issues of public interest and communicate findings to the public.

Civil Liberties: Fundamental freedoms that protect individuals against unjustified interference, including freedom of expression, privacy, peaceful assembly, and association.

Content Moderation: The processes through which digital platforms review, label, restrict, remove, or otherwise manage material shared through their services.

Deepfake: Synthetic or manipulated audio, images, or videos generated or altered using digital technologies, including artificial intelligence, in ways that may create misleading impressions about people or events.

Media and Information Literacy: The ability to access, evaluate, verify, interpret, and responsibly use information across different media and digital platforms.

Information Integrity: The condition of an information environment in which people can access diverse, reliable, and trustworthy information while exercising their human rights and freedoms.

Digital Surveillance: The monitoring or collection of information about individuals' online activities or communications, which may raise privacy and freedom of expression concerns depending on the methods and circumstances involved.

Background of the Issue:

Freedom of expression has long been recognised as an essential element of human rights protection and public accountability. Following the Second World War, the United Nations adopted the UDHR in 1948, establishing Article 19 as a foundational international statement of the right to freedom of opinion and expression.

In 1966, the adoption of the ICCPR strengthened this protection through legally binding

obligations for states parties. Article 19 recognises the right to seek, receive, and impart information and ideas, while Article 19(3) establishes conditions under which certain restrictions may be imposed. These restrictions must be provided by law and necessary for specified legitimate purposes, including protecting the rights or reputations of others and safeguarding national security, public order, public health, or morals. The expansion of the internet during the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries changed the global information environment. Traditional newspapers and broadcasters were joined by digital news outlets, social networks, online forums, and messaging applications. Individuals gained the ability to publish information directly, while audiences obtained access to a wider range of perspectives and sources.

However, the growth of digital platforms also introduced new challenges. Recommendation

algorithms can influence which information users encounter, while automated accounts and coordinated networks may create misleading impressions of public opinion. Online advertising and engagement-based business models can provide incentives for distributing attention-grabbing material, although the effects differ across platforms and circumstances. The development of generative artificial intelligence has introduced further concerns. Realistic fabricated videos, audio recordings, and images can be produced with increasing accessibility. Such technologies have legitimate applications, including entertainment, education, and creative expression, but may also be used to impersonate public figures, fabricate evidence, and manipulate public debate.

The UN Human Rights Council has addressed these challenges through initiatives concerning

internet freedom, disinformation, and the protection of human rights online. In June 2024, the UN Secretary-General introduced the Global Principles for Information Integrity, calling for a comprehensive approach involving governments, technology companies, media organisations, researchers, and civil society. The framework emphasises transparency, public empowerment, healthy incentives, and the protection of independent and pluralistic media. United Nations +1

Despite these developments, disagreements remain concerning the appropriate role of

governments in regulating online content. Some stakeholders support stronger regulatory measures to address deliberate deception and harmful manipulation, while others warn that poorly designed laws may weaken press freedom and enable censorship. The HRC must

therefore establish approaches that address genuine harms while preserving the rights and freedoms necessary for an independent information environment.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue:

The international community has introduced several initiatives to address disinformation and protect freedom of expression in the digital age. One of the most important foundations is the ICCPR, which establishes the international legal framework for freedom of expression. Article 19 protects the exchange of information and ideas, while Article 20 requires states parties to prohibit certain forms of propaganda for war and advocacy of national, racial, or religious hatred that constitutes incitement to discrimination, hostility, or violence. These provisions demonstrate the need to distinguish between protected expression and categories of speech subject to specific legal restrictions. The UN Human Rights Committee's General Comment No. 34, adopted in 2011, further clarified the scope of Article 19. It addressed the importance of free public debate, access to information, and media independence, while emphasising that restrictions must comply with the Covenant's requirements. The Human Rights Council has also adopted initiatives concerning the promotion, protection, and enjoyment of human rights on the internet. These efforts reaffirm the principle that the rights individuals enjoy offline must also be protected online. They are relevant to internet access, digital censorship, online participation, and the ability to seek and communicate information. Another significant development was the publication of the UN Global Principles for Information Integrity in 2024. The principles recommend a multi-stakeholder approach that includes stronger media independence, public empowerment, transparency, research, and improvements to the incentives

shaping digital information distribution. They recognise that addressing disinformation requires more than removing individual pieces of content; it also requires strengthening the broader information environment. UNESCO has also supported media development, journalist safety, and media and information literacy initiatives. These efforts contribute to the ability of individuals to evaluate sources and recognise misleading content, while helping journalists operate independently. Technology companies have developed additional responses, including content labels, fact-checking partnerships, user reporting systems, restrictions on coordinated inauthentic behaviour, and policies concerning manipulated media. However, the effectiveness and transparency of these measures vary across platforms. Concerns remain about inconsistent enforcement, inadequate appeals procedures, and the disproportionate removal of lawful content.

Therefore, although existing international and national initiatives provide a foundation for addressing disinformation, continued cooperation is needed to ensure that measures are effective, transparent, accessible, and consistent with international human rights law.

Possible Solutions:

When addressing disinformation and freedom of expression, the Human Rights Council can consider several measures to develop a balanced and internationally cooperative approach.

- Establishing Human Rights-Compliant Regulatory Frameworks: The Committee should

encourage states to review legislation concerning disinformation, online safety, and digital communications. Legal definitions should be sufficiently precise, and any restrictions must satisfy applicable international human rights requirements. Broad or ambiguous provisions that permit arbitrary censorship should be avoided.

- Promoting Independent Journalism: States should protect journalists against intimidation,

arbitrary detention, violence, and inappropriate political interference. The Committee should encourage safeguards for editorial independence, confidential sources, investigative reporting, and access to public information. Support for independent media should be transparent and should not compromise editorial autonomy.

- Strengthening Media and Information Literacy: Governments, educational institutions, civil

society organisations, and international bodies should develop programmes that teach individuals how to verify information, assess source credibility, recognise manipulated content, and distinguish factual reporting from opinion. These programmes should be accessible in local languages and adapted to different educational and technological contexts.

- Increasing Digital Platform Transparency: Technology companies should be encouraged to

publish regular reports explaining their content moderation practices, the handling of coordinated manipulation, and the operation of recommendation systems. Appropriate transparency can help researchers and the public understand how online information is distributed without requiring the disclosure of personal data or legitimately confidential information.

- Supporting Independent Fact-Checking: The Committee should encourage cooperation

between independent media organisations, academic institutions, researchers, and civil society to verify public claims and provide accessible corrections. Fact-checking initiatives should follow transparent methodologies and remain independent from political interference.

- Addressing AI-Generated Disinformation: States and technology companies should cooperate

on practical measures such as synthetic-media labelling, content provenance standards, and verification tools. These measures should focus on deceptive uses that create demonstrable risks while protecting legitimate satire, artistic expression, and other lawful uses of AI.

- Protecting Privacy and Civil Liberties: Investigations into coordinated disinformation should

respect privacy and other applicable human rights. Governments should ensure that digital surveillance is subject to appropriate legal safeguards and independent oversight. Broad monitoring of political opinions or lawful journalism should not be treated as an automatic or unrestricted counter-disinformation measure.

- Improving Public Communication: Governments should provide timely, accessible, and

evidence-based information during elections, public health emergencies, and periods of conflict. Transparent communication and prompt corrections can reduce uncertainty while allowing journalists and citizens to question official claims.

- Strengthening International Cooperation: The HRC should encourage collaboration among

states, UNESCO, OHCHR, technology companies, independent media, and civil society. Cooperation may include sharing research, developing technical expertise, supporting local-language verification, and exchanging good practices concerning rights-respecting regulation.

- Supporting Developing Countries: International organisations and development partners

should assist countries facing limited resources in strengthening independent media, improving digital infrastructure, developing cybersecurity capacity, and expanding access to reliable information. Such support should respond to local needs and preserve the independence of participating organisations.

- Establishing Effective Appeals Mechanisms: Digital platforms should provide accessible

procedures through which users can challenge content removals, account suspensions, and other significant moderation decisions. Clear explanations and appropriate review processes can help reduce arbitrary restrictions and improve public confidence.

- Monitoring the Impact of Anti-Disinformation Policies: States and relevant institutions should

assess whether their measures reduce demonstrable harms while preserving freedom of expression. Evaluation should consider effects on journalists, civil society, minority communities, access to information, and lawful political participation.

Other Relevant Information:

The challenges associated with disinformation vary across regions and national contexts. States differ in their technological infrastructure, media systems, legal frameworks, and capacity to regulate digital platforms. Developing countries may face particular difficulties in financing independent journalism, expanding internet access, and establishing reliable fact-checking networks. International assistance should therefore account for these differences rather than assuming that a single policy can be implemented effectively everywhere. The protection of independent journalism is particularly important because journalists can investigate claims, verify sources, expose wrongdoing, and provide alternative perspectives. When journalists face intimidation or censorship, the public may lose access to information necessary for accountability. However, journalism itself is not immune from mistakes, and independent media organisations should be encouraged to maintain professional verification standards, transparent corrections, and responsible reporting practices. Artificial intelligence presents both opportunities and challenges. Automated tools can help identify manipulated media and analyse coordinated campaigns, but detection systems can also produce inaccurate results. Overreliance on automated moderation may therefore result in the removal of legitimate material or the failure to identify harmful content. Human oversight, transparent procedures, and accessible appeals are important considerations. Another important concern is the concentration of power within digital platforms. A small number of companies control substantial portions of online communication and can influence which information becomes visible to large audiences. Greater transparency, independent research, and appropriate accountability can help address these concerns while preserving the legitimate rights of users and service providers. The Committee should also distinguish between criticism of public authorities and deliberate information manipulation. Governments must not assume that information is disinformation simply because it challenges official positions. Likewise, protecting freedom of expression does not eliminate the need to address conduct that falls within legally defined restrictions under international human rights law. Finally, the international response must recognise that information integrity depends on public trust, independent institutions, reliable journalism, and access to diverse sources of information. The HRC should therefore focus on solutions that strengthen these foundations while ensuring that efforts to counter disinformation do not become instruments for suppressing lawful expression.

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